



Gareth Evans

THE KEY IN MY HAND

Opening Heaven

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The Key in My Hand

Gareth Evans

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Matthew 10:8

About the Author

Gareth Evans

1938–

Gareth Evans, born in 1938 in Merthyr Tydfil, is an itinerant pastor, teacher, and author. He studied physics, taught globally, authored devotionals, and now ministers to the hurting church through his website. Gareth, married to Anne, has three daughters, eight grand children, and fourteen great-grand children. His teachings emphasize practical faith and biblical wisdom. With a unique blend of scientific background and spiritual insight, Evans brings clarity to complex theological concepts.

Read the full biography at <https://ochorus.com/authors/gareth-evans/>

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Personal Profile

Gareth, and his wife Anne, were both born and raised in Wales. They married in 1961 after he had received his Bachelors of Science with honors in Physics as well as a Diploma of Education from the University of Wales. In 1975 they immigrated to Canada where Gareth continued in his chosen profession as a secondary school physics teacher. In 1979 he was invited to pastor a church in Kitchener, Ontario with the Christian and Missionary Alliance.

Four years later, he received a call to Victoria, British Columbia where he pastored for the next eight years, and where they still reside. In 1990 Gareth was invited to serve as the chaplain on board the Mercy Ship, M/V Anastasis, working between Europe and West Africa. There he and Anne ministered to the crew and had many opportunities to speak at churches, pastors' seminars, and missionary conferences.

Since leaving the ship in 1994 Gareth has traveled extensively, teaching at discipleship training schools and various conferences. Gareth and Anne have three daughters and nine grandchildren.

Foreword by Keith Price

There can surely be no better recommendation for a book than its having stood the test of clinical trial. That such a test has been applied to the principles enunciated here is surely adequate endorsement.

As you read these pages you will sense a shepherd's heart.

Though a man of science, this man of God has no time for ivory towers. Having gone through the fires of life's uphill experiences himself, he understands what others feel in times of struggle.

Gareth Evans has proved these principles not only in pastoral work in Victoria, British Columbia, but also further afield in places as diverse as Mexico, Africa, Europe, and Australia where he has been invited to present the material to many different groups of churches and Christian leaders.

Because of his high view of the inspiration of the scriptures from which he draws these lessons, I am confident that they will retain their value until we, being made perfect, no longer need to take the initiative to restore broken relationships.

Keith Price Victoria, British Columbia March, 1996

Priorities

The Covenant Feast

It was a hot, dusty day as Peter and John, disciples of Jesus, entered the city of Jerusalem. They had come to celebrate Pesach, the Feast of the Passover, and were even now following a man, carrying a pitcher of water, who would lead them to the place where the feast was to be prepared.

As the Lord had told them, it had not been difficult to find their guide, for the sight of a man carrying a pitcher of water was uncommon. That was a task usually done by the women.

He led them to a pleasant two-story house where the host greeted them warmly. When they had told him their errand, they were ushered into a large, furnished room on the upper floor.

It did not take them long to prepare the low-lying table since the requirements for the feast were well known to both. Bowls of bitter herbs were alternated with plates of apples, cinnamon, and almonds. A flask of salt water and some boiled eggs were placed beside the vessels of wine and there were several portions of the unleavened bread they called “matzah.” Soon the hour arrived and Jesus came with the rest of the disciples.

There was a buzz of excitement and animated conversation as they entered the upper room. This was to be a celebration time, the happiest time of the year for all Jews; when they were reminded again of the great faithfulness of Jehovah. Had He not delivered them from the bondage of Egypt so

many years ago? Could He not still deliver them from the present oppression of the Romans?

To the disciples of Jesus this time was probably even more exciting. They were wondering if the day was near when their master would reveal Himself to the nation as the long-awaited Messiah who came to set them free as prophesied by the prophets of old. They felt they were at a strategic time in the history of their people. Indeed, this past week had been rather unusual, and things were coming to a head. It was obvious that the religious leaders were very shaken by both the teachings and popularity of Jesus.

I can imagine that the conversation of the disciples was centered entirely around the events of this past week and wondering just what significance they had. I'm sure Peter couldn't stop talking about the triumphal entry into Jerusalem just five days earlier, when the crowds had laid their garments on the dusty road and torn branches from the palm trees to wave, as they cried out, "Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord, even the king of Israel" (John 12:13).

I can imagine him, head held high, chest out, as he led the donkey's colt, upon which the master sat. John and James, the Zealots (sons of thunder), would have been more impressed with the way their master had turned over the tables of the money changers and driven them from the temple. "Did you see the look on the High Priest's face? Brother, was he mad!"

They all lowered themselves to a reclining position alongside the table, still happy in their celebratory mood: it was party time. Jesus looked on with pleasure as His friends celebrated, but He knew something that had eluded their understanding: tomorrow He would die.

What would you do if your doctor told you that you only had a short time to live? Of course, you'd ask for a second opinion! And if that also confirmed that you would soon leave this world, your constant compan-

ions, and friends? I know what I would do. I would quickly finish my present activities and arrange to be with those most precious to me: my wife, our daughters, and their families.

I would want to tell them how much I love them and how proud I am of them. I would encourage them to go on with Jesus, serving Him and living a life to the praise of His glory.

I would ask them if there is anything for which I need to apologize to them, any hurts, any unkind words or thoughtlessness. I would want to make very sure that there was nothing left undone that could be done in bonding our relationship one with the other.

I would find very little time to talk about trivial things such as the latest sports scores or gossip, which occupy so much of my time otherwise. Indeed, all I'd be doing would be dealing with priorities . And that night, at the paschal feast, that is just what the Lord was going to do with His disciples - deal with priorities !

His Requirements

As was customary, they had all removed their shoes as they entered this upper room. Their feet were dusty, and the sand between their toes made them feel rather uncomfortable.

Soon a murmur of discontent could be heard. The bowls of water were on a table near the door and there were towels available, but where was the servant girl whose job it was to wash their feet to refresh them? She should have been here when they arrived!

I can imagine that it must have been Peter who would be the first to speak out what they were all thinking. He is so much like me - always putting his foot in his mouth! "Where's the girl? My feet are itching. Has someone made a mistake and forgotten to tell her? Who planned this feast?

Who's on the committee?" An embarrassed whispering would be heard as the others tried to tell him to be quiet. After all, it was the Master who had made the arrangements! And He doesn't make mistakes; even when we cannot understand His purposes.

Jesus rose from the table and walked toward the bowls of water.

"Oh good," thought Peter, "He's going to call the girl."

Jesus removed His outer garment, clothed Himself with a towel, picked up a bowl of water, and turned... towards Peter!

"Oh no," thought Peter, "He's going to ask me to do it!"

Instead, Jesus washes the dusty feet of Peter and then, those of all the others, including Judas Iscariot who would betray Him and bring about the suffering He was anticipating that night. Can you imagine the Lord looking up into the eyes of Judas as He washed his feet? What did He see in those eyes?

Fear? Or guilt? What did Judas see in His master's eyes? I wonder, was he able to look? Such love!

Jesus returned the bowl and towel to their place by the door, put on His outer garment, and turned toward the disciples.

"I give you an example," He said, "as I have done to you, so do you to one another" (John 13:1-20).

The first priority of discipleship is servanthood. We are charged by the Lord to be servants. It is essential if we desire to be like Him, who came not to be served, but to serve (Matthew 20:28). It is the condition of greatness in the Kingdom of Heaven and an evidence of being filled with the Spirit (Ephesians 5:18,21).

I do not think that the Lord meant for us to follow Him literally in washing one another's feet (though that is a great blessing to experience), but rather, that we are to seek to refresh one another from the dust and dirt of walking in this world. It is impossible to live in this world without some

of its dirt rubbing off on you. How seldom can one read a newspaper, watch the television, or chat with neighbors or colleagues without being infected by its poison? Gossiping and grumbling, so common even among believers, soon rob us of the joy of walking the Christian way. We need the cleansing words, the refreshment and encouragement of other believers. We need to have our feet washed! That is the purpose of Christian fellowship; however, there is often just as much 'dirt' thrown about among believers as among those of the world!

Not only are we called to serve one another in the Body of Christ, but we are also challenged to be servants to those who would even betray our Lord and not be one of His followers.

Jesus washed the feet of Judas knowing all that was in his heart. He saw his doubts and frustrations, knew his politicking and deceit, yet He did not hesitate to wash his feet.

When He finished this task He invited all those who would recognize Him as master, to do the same.

To have the attitude of a servant is not easy in our self-centered world. It requires humility - knowing oneself as one truly is - and acceptance of oneself. When we see ourselves 'in Christ' we are not threatened by what others may think of us. Who cares what others may say when we know we are pleasing to the Lord? Our confidence is in Him and in His promises.

Jesus knew what His commission was, where He had come from, and what His destiny was (John 13:3). This confidence was the foundation of His servanthood. The Father had given Him authority, had sent Him into the world, and would receive Him back again.

We have the same commission and the same destiny! The World may call us weak or spineless, trying to manipulate our servant attitude to their own ends. They will take your coat, compel you to go with them a mile, and make you their slave.

Jesus told us, if that should happen, to give them also your shirt and go the second mile! In doing so, you are removing yourself from their slavery and making yourself a voluntary servant (Matthew 5:40-41).

Shortly after Judas had left the room to do his dirty work, Jesus taught His disciples a second requirement. “A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another” (John 13:34-35). Note that this is a commandment, not an option! Have you ever tried to measure just how much He loves you? That is the only scale by which He will measure how much you love “one another!”

It would be impossible if it were not for His grace and the indwelling Holy Spirit He gives.

“To live above with those I love, O, that will be glory! To live below with those I know - well, that’s a different story!”

(Unknown Author).

We may not like one another, but we are commanded to love one another! That means no gossiping and no backstabbing, but instead honoring, preferring one another, bearing one another’s burden, and so much more... A third requirement was placed before the disciples. “If you love me, you will keep my commandments” (John 14:15). He calls us to be obedient to His word. The Old Testament prophet, Samuel, rebuked the disobedient King Saul saying, “Has the Lord as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the Lord? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to listen than the fat of rams.

For rebellion is as the sin of divination, and presumption is as iniquity and idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the Lord, he has also rejected you from being king” (1 Samuel 15:22-23).

Because Saul did not obey the word of the Lord God, he lost his kingdom and authority. When Jesus spoke to the multitudes, those who heard Him were filled with amazement for He spoke as one having great authority (Matthew 7:28-29).

We who recognize Him as Saviour must also acknowledge that He is Lord. What He says has the greatest of authority.

We need to be sensitive to hear and recognize His voice day by day. He said that we, His sheep, should recognize His voice. Above all, we should hear Him speak to us through the Scriptures and obey what He says. All believers should be students of the written Word, living in obedience to its precepts.

Jesus' requirements for His disciples are that we serve one another, love one another, and obey His Word.

His Promises

Besides the three requirements He placed before His disciples, Jesus also promised them rich blessings. He would come again and receive them to Himself having prepared a place "in [His] Father's house" (John 14:2) for them. They would do greater works than He did as He would send them another Helper and would answer the prayers they asked according to His will. They were to know the blessing of being in Christ, and to experience the Father's love.

The Helper, the Holy Spirit, would come to dwell in them and would lead them to the truth and knowledge of God's will; He would bring to their remembrance all they had been taught by Jesus.

"Let not your hearts be troubled. Believe in God; believe also in me" (John 14:1).

“Peace I leave with you; my peace I give to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you. Let not your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid” (John 14:27).

“These things I have spoken to you, that my joy may be in you, and that your joy may be full” (John 15:11).

He promised them - and us - a peace that the world cannot give or take away, a joy whose measure is fullness, and a presence who is none other than the Spirit Himself, never to leave us or forsake us (Deuteronomy 31:6).

Have you experienced these in your walk with the Lord? I certainly have, but I long for more!

The experience of these promises is contingent on us being servants , lovers , and obedient to His Word.

A Covenant People

The Agape Feast

“Jesus took bread and when He had given thanks, He broke it and said, ‘This is My Body, broken for you. Take and eat!’”

(1 Corinthians 11:23-24). They all did and, in so doing, identified themselves with the Body of Christ.

“In the same way He took the cup also, after supper, saying, ‘This cup is the new covenant in My blood; do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me’” (1 Corinthians 11:25-26). I am struck that none of those present asked Him what He meant when He said this. I can only assume that they all understood.

A covenant is an agreement between two parties. “You do this for me, and I’ll do that for you!” Today, when men make covenants it is essential that proof be available in the form of signatures attached to the written agreement. Sadly, the word of a gentleman is no longer acceptable. In the time of Jesus, covenants were sealed over a common drink. It would not have been blood, as more recently among the Native Indians of North America and the tribesmen of Africa, though all the covenants of the Old Testament days would have been signified by the shedding of blood in the slaying of a sacrificial animal. Indeed, one was said to ‘cut the covenant’ rather than make one.

An interesting story is told concerning Dr. Livingstone, the great pioneer missionary to Africa. He, with his guides and bearers, was often taken captive by warrior tribesmen as they journeyed through the dark continent.

On one occasion, the captives were brought before a hostile chief who began to berate them for trespassing on his territory. As he was getting angrier at Livingstone's silence, a guide leaned over to the missionary and urged him to 'cut the covenant.' Livingstone did not understand what was being requested, but he soon recoiled in dismay as he watched his Christian servant and a chosen young man from the hostile tribe, perform what was to him, a pagan act. They made a small cut in their forearms, gathered the blood into a bowl and drank it together!

The chief then stepped forward and took hold of the string by which Livingstone was leading a goat, the source of the milk he so enjoyed. Livingstone was dismayed and then surprised as the chief pressed a gift into his hands - the copper-tipped staff with which he had met the trespassing party. They were then led to a hut where they would spend the night after receiving a meal from their captors.

Some time later, while journeying through another region of Africa, Livingstone was captured again and brought before another hostile chief. This time, however, the chief fell on his knees before the missionary. It was only then that understanding came. When the young guide had 'cut the covenant' on behalf of Livingstone, and had sealed it by the drinking of blood, an agreement was made between them and the tribe, especially between Livingstone and the chief.

As a token of that covenant agreement, the chief had given his staff, a symbol of his commitment and support. The second hostile chief had recognized the staff, understood that Livingstone had a blood brother and had yielded to that superior power and authority.

Jesus has made such a covenant with us! We can now walk tall in this crippled world by His authority! We have a blood brother Who shed His blood, drank it to the bitter dregs on our behalf, and gave us the authority of His name (Acts 3:16)!

Our enemy, Satan, and his henchmen, sin and death, should have no dominion over us (Romans 6:14)!

When Jesus invited His disciples to drink the ‘covenant cup,’ they knew they were indicating their agreement to the terms of a new covenant. So it is every time we take the emblems at the Lord’s table. As we eat the bread, we are declaring ourselves to be the body of Christ . As we drink the cup, we are covenanting again to be servants to one another, lovers of one another, and obedient to His Word .

An Unworthy Manner

In his letter to the Corinthians, Paul exhorts us to be very careful in taking these emblems. If we drink the Lord’s cup “in an unworthy manner” we may well drink judgment to ourselves, not recognizing the Lord’s body. “For this reason many among you (believers) are weak and sick” (1 Corinthians 11:30).

If I bear animosity in my heart to another, or am not living as a servant , lover , or in obedience , my taking of the bread and cup is hypocrisy. I am failing to recognize the other as one with me in the Body of Christ. This may well result in weakness and sickness coming upon me. This is not from the Lord - He is not the author of sickness, but I have given the devil a foothold (2 Corinthians 2:11), and he certainly knows how to manipulate such footholds for his advantage!

Praying for the Sick

Now I have an understanding of what James meant when he wrote, “Is anyone among you sick? Let him call for the elders of the church, and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer of faith will save the one who is sick, and the Lord will raise him up. And if he has committed sins, he will be forgiven” (James 5: 14-15).

I often wondered why the elders had to be involved. Couldn't anyone pray? Do elders have more prayer power than loving friends and family? I do not now believe that calling the elders has anything to do with their prayer power, but rather their authority . This verse must be linked with Paul's warning above, as they are the only verses that give any reference to reasons why believers may be sick or weak. Of course, we also are subject to germs, diseases, and sickness just as anyone in the world, but Paul's warning must be strongly expressed to believers.

Should the elders discern that the believer's sickness may be associated with a wrong attitude to others in the Body of Christ, they must exercise their authority as elders in the church, to charge that one to be reconciled. Only then can they pray, anointing him with oil (a symbol of the Holy Spirit's blessing and protection) in the name of the Lord. The sick one - the guilty one - will be restored and forgiven.

The Lord's Prayer

Having taught His disciples the priorities of His heart, our Lord lifted His eyes toward Heaven and spoke to His Father.

One should take time to read John 17 to hear the cry of Jesus' heart on the night before He died. Let me walk with you through these wonderful words, emphasizing a major theme.

“Father, I have finished the work You gave Me to do... I have manifested Your name (attributes) to these men... and they have kept Your word. I ask on their behalf... for they are Yours. They are not of the world, even as I am not of the world. As You have sent Me into the world, I have also sent them into the world. I do not only ask for these but also for all who will believe in Me through their word (which includes you and I). That they may all be one ... that the world may believe. I have given them Your glory... that they may be one ... as We are One. That they may be perfected in unity , that the world may know that You sent Me and that You love them even as You love Me... I have made Your name (attributes) known to them... that the love with which You love Me may be in them, and I in them” (John 17).

God’s name was revealed to Moses when they met on Mount Sinai; therefore, we can be certain that He is “ The Lord God, merciful and gracious, longsuffering and abundant in goodness and truth, keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin” (Exodus 34:6-7).

Truly, Jesus manifested these same attributes to all He met.

God’s Gospel Tract

I cannot take even one page out of the Bible and use it as an evangelical tract to give to an unbelieving friend. I can quote from John 3 or follow “The Romans Road” which explains to them the way of salvation. I can give them the “Four Steps” or “God’s Wonderful Plan of Salvation,” but I cannot tear one page out of the Bible and give it away as a gospel tract.

However, I can take whole chapters and even books, to point out God’s priorities to the believer: His way of salvation. He has declared that when His people are walking in unity as servants , as lovers and in obedience , the world will know and believe !

We are His Gospel tract! It's time we got our priorities right and in line with His priorities! We are quick to speak when we detect heresy of doctrine in one another - isn't it time we were just as quick to act against heresy of practice, seeing the many divisions among believers, so evident to the world?

“For the anxious longing of all creation waits eagerly for the revealing of the Sons of God” (Romans 8:19).

The Body of Christ

One Body

“So we, though many, are one body in Christ, and individually members one of another” (Romans 12:5).

The apostle Paul takes up the theme of the Lord’s upper room prayer to teach us that the relationship called for in one-to-the-other serving and loving, is best demonstrated in the example of a living body. He sees the church as the living Body of Christ instituted by God. It is not a man-made organization, but a God-made organism - a living, vital reality. It is the training and exercise ground for serving and loving. This is why Christian fellowship is so important.

John Donne, a sixteenth century Anglican priest, wrote, “No man is an island, entire of itself; every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main. If a clod be washed away by the sea, Europe is the less, as well as if a promontory were, as well as if a manor of thy friend’s or of thine own were: any man’s death diminishes me, because I am involved in mankind, and therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee.”

His sentiments could well be those of a member of the Body of Christ, recognizing his interdependence on all other parts of that body.

Islam teaches that Mohammed was called by God to complete what Jesus failed to do! Muslims recognize Jesus as a great prophet, second only to Mohammed, but they believe He failed in that He was not able to make

all people into one nation. Islam calls peoples of all nations to be one as Muslims. They have failed to understand that the unity Jesus came to bring was for those who are members of His kingdom, and not one of this world. How tragic that there is such obvious disunity in that kingdom. No wonder Islam is growing so rapidly!

At conversion, the new birth, we were, “by one Spirit all baptized into one body” (1 Corinthians 12:13). This includes Baptists, Anglicans, Pentecostals, and whatever group you belong to. Not the denominations, but the individuals within all such groups who know the Lord as a personal Savior, and know their sins are forgiven through the work finished on Calvary. The baptism into the Body must not be confused with the baptism into the Spirit, experienced by the disciples on the day of Pentecost, and by many since that day. The former is “by the Spirit into the Body” whereas the latter is “by the Lord Jesus into the Spirit” (Luke 3:16). We are to be “in Christ” for justification, and Christ is to be “in us” for sanctification.

Fullness of the Spirit

One major division in the body is due to various doctrines concerning this baptism of the Spirit.

Are tongues the initial evidence of being so filled? Are they evidence at all? I am not getting into that argument except to say that, whichever view we hold, we should not make our disagreement a cause for division, that way we are certainly not exhibiting the reality of any fullness of the Holy Spirit!

He comes to make the presence of Christ, and His will, real to us. He leads us into truth. I find it rather striking that, when Paul exhorts us to be “filled with the Spirit” (Ephesians 5:18), he follows by giving us three evi-

dences of a life so filled: 1. A worshiping attitude speaking to one another in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord (Ephesians 5:19).

2. A thankful attitude always giving thanks for all things in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ to God, even the Father (Ephesians 5:20).

3. A servant attitude and be subject to one another in the fear of Christ (Ephesians 5:21).

Don't tell me that you are a Spirit-filled Christian unless these three are evident in your life!

Paul then continues in his letter to the Ephesians by showing how this third evidence is worked out in our relationships as: husband and wife, children and parents, and workers and masters (Ephesians 5:22-6:9).

The Local Church

I am not among those who consider denominations as such to be evil. I believe that the Lord established most of them to enable us to mature as believers within a group of people most like us in personality and persuasion; however, when our groupings cause us to be divided from those within the Body of Christ who do not share our opinions concerning styles of worship, interpretation of Scriptures, and emphases, we are in danger of bringing condemnation upon ourselves. We may not like one another, but we are commanded to love one another!

There are three major Scripture portions where the apostle outlines his understanding of the Body of Christ.

1. Ephesians 4:1-16 → We are challenged to walk in a manner worthy of our calling showing humility, gentleness, patience, love, and being diligent to preserve the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. For, he declares, "There is ONE BODY" (Ephesians 4:4). He continues by writing about

some of the grace gifts in verse seven given to that Body. They are ministry gifts of apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers, which are given “for the equipping of the saints... unto maturity” (Ephesians 4:13).

2. Romans 12:1-8 → We are challenged again to give ourselves as living sacrifices with renewed minds. All members of the Body do not have the same function, but we are all interdependent on one another. We all have different grace gifts (Romans 12:6) with which to serve one another.

Therefore, we must, “Let love be genuine. Abhor what is evil; hold fast to what is good. Love one another with brotherly affection. Outdo one another in showing honor” (Romans 12:9-10).

3. 1 Corinthians 12-14 → We cannot separate chapters 12 and 14 from that great chapter on love, chapter 13! The first chapter deals with the doctrines of the Body and the charismata given to that Body. Note that these charismata are given to the individual, not for their own use, but for the benefit of the whole Body!

Then Paul expands on his teaching concerning the Body by showing just how foolish it is for one part of the Body to claim that they do not need the other parts! The eye cannot say to the hand, “I have no need of you” or again the head to the feet, “I have no need of you” (1 Corinthians 12:21). We need one another!

At the end of this chapter, he gathers together the lists of grace gifts he recorded in Ephesians and Romans showing them all to be among his long list of charismata .

Such gifts are of little value unless exercised with love (1 Corinthians 13) and properly in an orderly manner (1 Corinthians 14).

Are you fully functioning in the Body of Christ? Are you grounded in a local church, serving others, loving others, and obedient to His Word? If your ministry is wider than the local church, are you in the right relation-

ship with God to appoint leaders, and be accountable to them as a member of the same local expression of the Body?

Some might seek to be an arm reaching out, others a voice speaking to this world, but I often see myself as nothing more glamorous than a big toe! As a former pastor, I was often working in dark and smelly places, feeling under pressure, dealing with peoples' problems (sand between the toes).

However, I feel I am privileged when asked to minister because I get to bring balance to the Body. That surely, is the main function of the big toe!

The Tragic Truth

God's desire, and the priority on the heart of Jesus, is that He will have a people whose love for one another, and attitude of servanthood will be such a witness to this world that men and women will be crying out to know our Lord. They will want to know the secret of our peace, joy, and harmony. They will watch our marriages, homes, children, and workplaces, not to criticize, but to know our secrets.

Having urged his readers to be "filled with the Spirit," and expressing one evidence of being so filled, as being "subject to one another in the fear of Christ" (Ephesians 5:21), Paul gives examples of how this should be in our relationships.

Christian Marriage → Ephesians 5:22-33

If Christian marriages were what they are supposed to be, with both parties Spirit-filled and submitted to one another, honoring, and preferring the other, they would be the mystery revealed to a watching world. Men would see the relationship that Jesus has with His bride, the church, and would be drawn to know Him as the foundation for his marriage also. There would be a steady path of seekers coming to our home or church door, rather than rushing, as they now do, to the divorce courts!

Women would want to honor their own husband above all other men, because of the love they receive, and men would want to love their wives be-

cause of the honor they receive.

Rather than a vicious circle of abuse and retaliation which is so common in the world, there would be a delicious circle of blessing one another in Christ.

It is so tragic that divorce is so common among Christian believers. What kind of witness is that?

The Christian Home → Ephesians 6:1-4

Where parents are in the right relationships with the Lord and with one another, their children mature in a secure, loving home. Most of the counseling I do as a pastor has to do with wounds received by children growing up in a rather different situation, though often “Christian” fathers fail to discipline (or discipline) their children and, instead, provoke them to anger (Colossians 3:21).

Christian counselors today speak of dysfunctional families where the child’s ‘love tank’ is not filled with the love it was created to receive, because the dysfunctional parents are incapable of providing that love. The child does not experience the love whose fruit is security, identity, self-esteem, acceptance, and encouragement. The child does not experience the love whose fruit is security, identity, self-esteem, acceptance, and encouragement.

Instead of growing up emotionally and spiritually healthy, they become just like their parents, dysfunctional. They never learn to walk tall in a world of bowed shoulders and broken hearts. The empty space in their love tank is filled with one thing: anger, which produces a life of rebellion to God’s purposes. Such children never learn to obey their parents in the Lord.

“Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger” (Colossians 3:21).

It is so tragic that so many rebellious children are the product of “Christian” homes. What kind of witness is that?

The Workplace → Ephesians 6:5-9

The Spirit-filled believer is called to be a witness in his workplace by displaying the attitude of a servant before his co-workers and employers and should be trustworthy to do his work well.

I am familiar with a teacher whose school was to be amalgamated with two others in a major reorganization. All the teachers from the three schools gathered together to form a Staff Association to speak on the teachers’ behalf to the School Governors, expressing their desires for the design of the new school buildings and their terms of employment.

One man was nominated and seconded for the position of president for this new association. Another was nominated and seconded. Then, much to his surprise, my friend was nominated. Immediately, the two others who had been nominated withdrew their names in order to second my friend’s nomination. No other names were presented and he was elected unanimously to represent all the staff. As he left the room he expressed amazement to a colleague. “Just wait till I tell my wife,” he said. “She’ll never believe me!” “Why not?” replied the colleague, “We all know you’re the only one we can trust to always speak the truth!”

My friend was the only Christian on the senior staff of those schools.

Sadly, I am often told by business men (Christians among them) that the worst people to do business with are Christians.

They want the most out of you for the least payment. They are the poorest at giving tips, and often the last in settling debts! Of course, it may well be that we are judged more harshly by the world than non-believers are, but that is to be expected!

We are called to have the attitude of servants. We should be living at a higher level of commitment and workmanship than the world! Sadly, we all know of Christian employers and workers who do not display a Spirit-filled work ethic or relationship with their colleagues. What kind of witness is that?

Worker Attrition

Most relevant research reveals that the number one reason for missionaries to leave the field is poor interpersonal relationships! They have studied for many years in Bible Schools and language seminaries, interned in home churches, invested a large portion of their lives in preparation, and, after one term overseas, have returned home bitter, disillusioned, embarrassed, and hurt. This ought not to be!

In North America, the average tenure for a pastor in a local church is fewer than five years. The first year is honeymoon, the second, familiarity. In the third year, disillusionment sets in with rumblings of discontent; both the pastor and the church members have unfulfilled expectations of one another.

The fourth year sees the discontent come to the surface, often with acrimony and accusations. People take sides, a lot of heat is generated, and the pastor leaves, usually saying, “I don’t have to put up with this!” What kind of witness is that?

Church Fights

Have you ever been involved in a church fight? It is not a pleasant thing! I know of one church, once over three hundred people, now non-existent. Everyone in that town seems to know some aspect of the story, and there

are many people, once faithful in attendance, who say that they will never attend a church again!

The wounds are real because the fighting was bitter. Believers would fire ‘gunshots’ at one another assassinating one another, which reverberated all around the town. Satan gloated, and the Lord wept!

Of course, most of our fighting is kept indoors, or is more subtle. I read an interesting newspaper article where it told of a group of ministers establishing support groups for pastors who had grievances against their church or church organization. It told of ministers in one denomination, who were “suing for big money,” and then added that churches are a lot more brutal to their pastors than businesses are to their employees, and that the most vicious are in the evangelical tradition (Christian Week (Canada), June 21, 94).

Look at the Saturday evening church ads in your local newspaper to see how we compete with one another in the arena of winning more people to our church - usually from some other church! It is well documented that most church growth is transfer growth, not conversion growth. Personal anecdotes are not to be commended, but I once had an interesting experience worth recounting.

It was early in the university year and all the local pastors were invited to meet with the students to tell them about our churches. We were given two minutes each to make our pitch.

I listened as, one after the other, pastors extolled the virtues of their churches. “We have a wonderful ‘College and Career Group’ and can send our bus to pick you up.” “You’ll really enjoy our music - it’s up-beat, just as young people like it!”

“Most of your fellow students attend our church since we are located near the campus.” I was roughly the 30th pastor in the line-up, and was pastoring a small, struggling work. When I stood, I told the students that we

were a small church with no special programs. We had nothing to offer them, except work if they wanted to help us reach our neighborhood for Christ.

I sat down - and the students broke into applause!

As the church grew, a substantial number of our congregation were university students. Why do we compete with one another for the sheep when we all serve the same Great Shepherd? What kind of witness is that?

Why do we find it so difficult to honor one another, to love , and serve one another? Is it simply our pride getting in the way while, at the same time, we speak about being filled with the Spirit? Or are we just ignorant of the fact that we are in a battle, and that the enemy is very cunning?

Be very sure of this! If it is the Lord's priority to have a people in right relationships with one another in obedience to His Word, it certainly is Satan's priority to mar such relationships! "Divide and conquer," might as well be his motto.

The Devices of Satan

When Jesus died on the cross and then rose again, He conquered Satan and his demonic hosts, taking away all their power, “having disarmed the powers and authorities He made a show of them openly” (Colossians 2:15). They now wage war through lies, deceit, and fear which he works into all areas of our lives: our attitudes, emotions, thoughts, and even the physical.

However, they only have power in these areas as we give it to them! The apostle Paul declared that we are not ignorant of his devices (2 Corinthians 2:11), but unfortunately that is just not true for the majority of believers today!

The Devil’s Opportunity

Have you ever been angry? Of course you have. Me too. And so was Jesus when He saw the money changers in the temple.

I’m sure He was also angry when He saw the multitudes in deep poverty and with much sickness. His heart grieved when He saw the results of the disobedience of Adam falling on all mankind. The feeling of anger is not sin. Feelings are not moral or immoral - they are amoral. What we do with our feelings, however, does matter, greatly. Paul exhorts us that when we are angry we must not sin. Then continues to add, “and do not let the sun go down on your anger” (Ephesians 4:26).

We must deal with the situation right away. If we allow the anger within to fester, it will produce a bitterness that will rob us of God's best. As long as we are in this world, people will do us wrong, and offenses will come. Jesus warned us of that (Luke 17:1). There might be a 'good' cause behind our anger within us, but He has given us His Holy Spirit to enable us to know grace in those times.

"Strive for peace with everyone, and for the holiness without which no one will see the Lord. See to it that no one fails to obtain the grace of God; that no 'root of bitterness' springs up and causes trouble, and by it many become defiled" (Hebrews 12: 15).

If we do not deal with the anger in the appropriate way (which we will discuss later), we are playing right into the hands of the enemy! Paul continues by saying "and do not give the devil an opportunity" (Ephesians 4:27). Later, in the same portion of Scripture dealing with our conversations with one another, he warns us that we may be grieving the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 4:30).

When we bear anger (or other wrong attitudes), the enemy has access to our thoughts, spreading his lies and deceit to drive a wedge further in. Soon it appears that reconciliation is impossible, and he has won that battle.

Jesus warned us to be on our guard (Luke 17:3) and Paul charged us to be sure that no advantage be taken of us by Satan (2 Corinthians 2:11). Both are in the context of forgiveness to those whom we perceive as having wronged us. An attitude of unforgiveness (like anger) gives the enemy an advantage - an opportunity - a foothold in our life. The opposite attitudes of forgiveness and peace defeat him.

The Roaring Lion

Have you ever seen a lion stalking its prey? I haven't, but I assume it is much like my cat stalking the birds or mice in our garden. He crouches very low and moves very slowly so as not to warn his intended prey of his intentions. He certainly doesn't let them know he is coming by making a loud meow!

What, then, does the apostle Peter mean when he tells us to "Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour" (1 Peter 5:8)?

In "Pilgrim's Progress" by John Bunyan, we read that Pilgrim was approaching the Palace Beautiful which was built for the relief and security of believers. He now understood why Timorous and Mistrust, others seeking the Celestial City, had fled past him in great fear, for the entranceway was guarded by two lions.

Immediately, Pilgrim's heart sank and he also became afraid.

If a lion came bounding into your room and roared at you, I imagine you would react like them - full of fear! I would!

Roaring lions have that effect on us - they are very frightening.

Soon, Pilgrim noticed that both lions were chained and that, so long as he walked a narrow path between them, neither could reach him to cause him harm. We need to understand that the lion, Satan, has had his teeth pulled and is chained.

He cannot harm the people of God so long as we keep to the narrow way. Even when we step off the narrow way, the Father's love reaches out to bring us back before the enemy can destroy us. However, he will roar, and many are defeated by their emotions reacting to the roar.

His roar is often that of the accuser, bringing condemnation.

It was the first time Mary had sung the solo parts in the youth choir. It went well except for that high note in the chorus where she was a little weak and wobbly. It was only a quiet voice whispering in her ear that told her, “You made a fool of yourself,” but it was the roar of the lion. She vowed never to sing in public again.

Pastor John had such high hopes when he began ministry at St. Peter’s church. Now, just two years later he was leaving.

The youth group had not grown in numbers as the senior pastor had expected, so John was invited to leave. The lion roared, “you’ll never be successful as a pastor. You’re a failure!” A week later, he reapplied for the secular job he had left when he first believed that God had called him into the pastorate.

Alec had slipped again. He so longed to be free from this filthy habit of smoking, but it was too tempting when he’d been offered this cigarette. Now he was feeling guilty, and the lion roared, “God can’t use you. You’re always letting Him down!”

Not only does the lion roar at every slip or failure, but he knows which of our emotions are the most likely to be affected by the roar. For some it is the emotion of guilt, for others, it’s fear. Many react to his roar in the emotions of low self-esteem, lacking confidence. Where do you react?

How sad when the roar of the lion comes through the thoughtless comment of another believer! It is important in the Body of Christ to affirm one another to counteract the lies - the roar of the devil!

The Archer

When one is about to wage a battle, it is good to occupy the high ground. This enables you to see their moves so that you can take the appropriate steps to counteract them. We need to understand as believers, the tremen-

dous privilege we have of being “in Christ.” Paul declares that God has “exalted Jesus, far above every rule and authority and power and dominion” (Ephesians 1:21).

To the Jews, these are the names of the ranks of the demonic army of Satan, but all of them are far beneath His feet. He has crushed the head of their master and has all authority over them. He wills us to exercise that authority so that we may learn to be overcomers. Those that would reign with Him must be worthy to wear a crown, and crowns are only to be given to the overcomers.

“[Christ has] raised us up with him and seated us with him in the Heavenly places in Christ Jesus” (Ephesians 2:6).

We must live on that higher ground where the only way Satan can reach us is by firing his fiery arrows. We have also been provided with a sure defense against those flaming missiles when Paul writes, “In all circumstances take up the shield of faith, with which you can extinguish all the flaming darts of the evil one” (Ephesians 6:16) As the enemy would throw his lies and accusations against us, we hold up our shield of faith, remembering that “faith comes by hearing... the Word of God” (Romans 10:17).

We need to know who we are and the privileges of being “in Christ .”

I am... • A child of God (John 1:12).

- A friend of Jesus (John 15:15).
- A joint-heir with Christ (Romans 8:17).
- Joined to the Lord (1 Corinthians 6:17).
- A member of His Body (Ephesians 5:30).
- Reconciled to God (2 Corinthians 5:18).
- God’s handiwork (Ephesians 2:10).
- A citizen of Heaven (Philippians 3:20).
- A new creation (2 Corinthians 5:17).
- Chosen by God (Colossians 3:12).

- A saint (Ephesians 1:1).
- A stranger to this world (1 Peter 2:11).
- What I am (1 Corinthians 15:10).
- Satan's enemy (1 Peter 5:8).
- Clothed in righteousness (Ephesians 4:24).
- God's dwelling place (1 Corinthians 3:16).
- A member of a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, and a people for God's own possession (1 Peter 2:9-10).

In Christ I... ● Am completely forgiven (Romans 5:1).

- Am greatly blessed (Ephesians 1:3).
- Am chosen to be holy (Ephesians 1:4).
- Am sealed by His Spirit (Ephesians 1:13).
- Am predestined to be His child (Ephesians 1:5).
- Have Christ within me (Colossians 1:27).
- Am made complete (Colossians 2:10).
- Am bought back from Satan (Ephesians 1:7).
- Am seated in Heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6).
- Am free from condemnation (Romans 8:1).
- Have direct access to God (Ephesians 2:18).
- May come to God confidently (Ephesians 3:12).

For a more complete list, read your Bible!

It used to be that there was a simple remedy for most minor ailments, "Just take two aspirins and go to bed!" Today, I have a simple remedy for most of the minor attacks of the enemy to offer.

Take two of the above Scriptures each day and meditate on them. Your faith will soon grow strong, and the fiery arrows will be less effective against you.

Unneeded Baggage

“Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us” (Hebrews 12:1).

Many are hindered in the battle, not because of the roaring lion or the arrows of lies, but because they have taken upon themselves a burden that they should not be carrying; they have been offended by someone and have taken umbrage.

I was at a viewing place, looking down on Gibraltar. There were many signs warning viewers not to feed the small monkeys that lived in the surrounding trees. Of course, some people chose to ignore the signs with the result that soon, a monkey would land on one's shoulders. While cameras were in action, the monkey would begin to tangle its fingers in the hair so that, when it became painful, the recipient found difficulty in its removal.

Satan has an army of trained ‘monkeys’ ready to jump on one's shoulder to tangle their fingers in their victim's hair.

We need to recognize the monkey of offense and quickly remove it before it robs us of our peace.

Many are hindered in the battle, not because they have been ‘wounded’ by others, but because they have taken upon themselves a burden that they should not be carrying. They have been offended by someone and have ‘taken umbrage.’

We must realize that offense and sin are very different.

Though the former may be a ‘fruit’ of the sinful life, it is not a deliberate sinful act of the one who offends. Indeed, we are told that Jesus was an ‘offense’ to the religious leaders of His time, and He was without sin. It is my belief that He deliberately caused offense on more than one occasion, as I shall present to you shortly.

There may be many causes for offense, but the following are the most common: ● Personality clashes : People will often use this phrase as an ‘excuse’ for not getting along with one another!

- False expectations : Probably, the number one reason pastors and churches separate. We are not very good at making our expectations known before offense occurs.

- Misunderstandings : Poor communication.

- Gifts and talents : I often see people envy others’ prominence, instead of feeling secure in their own ministry or ‘calling.’

- Pride : An affront to one’s ‘ego.’ (for example: a father who is angered (offended) by his son’s average grades in school, believing it reflects poorly on himself).

- Rebellion : The ‘old man’ refuses to die!

A great example of these offenses at work was when a church was undergoing a renovation - they were rebuilding their sanctuary. It had been two long years of hard work for the congregation who were building this church, but God had proven Himself to be faithful.

There were many stories of ‘miracles’ of provision from Jehovah Jireh. It was now time to decide the color scheme for the interior of the sanctuary, so a small committee was formed of members of the church and John, art master at the local school, was asked to lead the group. At their first meeting, John arrived with a portfolio outlining his suggestions (some say ‘decisions’) for the color scheme. It was not long before others present expressed their disagreement with his proposals, having some opinions of their own.

Finally, a vote was taken and a consensus decision made - that did not reflect the art teacher's views. John was offended and the reverberations of his offense were felt in that church for some time afterwards. Indeed, some even said that that was when the 'miracles' ceased.

John is no different than all of us! It is so easy to be offended without realizing the terrible negative impact this can have on ourselves and on the work of Christ. It is a major weapon used by Satan in defeating us in the battle. Be sure of this - offenses will come (Luke 17:1). Jesus told us of their certainty and warned us how we can be kept from stumbling at the offense: by responding to His requirements for discipleship, made in the Upper Room. Let us look at some Biblical examples of people who were offended. We shall seek the cause and note the results of their offense. Hopefully, we shall also discern the Lord's purposes in allowing the offenses to come. He has promised to deliver us from the 'evil one,' but has never promised to deliver us from offenses! He would, however, teach us to recognize the offense and to receive His grace in such times of testing.

The various translations of the New Testament can confuse us on this topic, so let us understand that the Greek word, "skandalon" is variously translated as "a stumbling block." In other words, "an offense," or "a falling away."

The Sower and the Seed → Matthew 13:18-21

In the verses above, Jesus teaches a crowd this well known parable as well as interprets the parable for them, likening the four types of soil to four types of hearers of the God's Word.

The 'stony places' describes the person who "hears the word and immediately receives it with joy, yet he has no root in himself, but endures for a

while, and when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately he falls away” (Matthew 13:20-21).

This is a believer who doesn’t like what the Bible teaches him. He had anticipated that being a Christian would be easy!

He wanted joy and peace, but wasn’t prepared to take up his cross (Matthew 16:24), to pay the price of servanthood. By and by, he is offended and falls away, the result being no fruit !

A Prophet Without Honour → Matthew 13:54-57

Jesus came to His own town of Nazareth where He taught in the synagogue. His neighbors were astonished at His teaching, questioning where He received such wisdom. “Isn’t this the carpenter’s son?” they said. “We’ve known him since childhood! Who does he think he is?” There is a common phrase, ‘familiarity often breeds contempt’ and as we read in verse 57, those from Jesus’ hometown “took offense at Him.”

How many young men and women, responding to God’s call on their lives, have tried to answer that call, but have been hindered by the greater ‘wisdom’ of their neighbors: family, friends, and church leaders! I am reminded of the old prophet in 1 Kings 13 who was offended because God was using another young man to proclaim His word. Because of his offense, the old prophet deceived the young man, the result being the silencing of his witness, through death!

As a result of their offense in Nazareth, “he did not do many mighty works there, because of their unbelief” (Matthew 13:58). A sure way to stop the Lord moving in miraculous ways in your life, is to take offense. The result of their being offended was no miracles !

The Betrayer → Matthew 26:6-14

Jesus was at the home of Simon, a leper, when a woman came in with an expensive box of perfumed ointment. She broke it over the Lord's feet and began to wipe them with her hair, so that the fragrance filled the house. Matthew tells us that the disciples were offended when they saw this 'waste,' declaring that the perfume could have been sold for a high price and the money given to the poor (Matthew 26:8).

Just after this, Judas Iscariot went to the chief priests in order to betray his master (Matthew 26:14-16). In John's account of this event, we are told it was Judas himself, who made the complaint, being offended, "not because he cared about the poor, but because he was a thief, and having charge of the money bag he used to help himself to what was put into it" (John 12:6).

I remember when a well-known international charity spent over one million dollars to make a documentary film about their work. Many of their supporters expressed indignation at such 'waste' and withheld their monthly contributions. They felt themselves to be justly indignant; however, within one year, the proceeds from the showing of that film, exceeded five times the cost of making it! I believe we should rather be on the cautious side when we come to spend the Lord's money, but taking offense could be a greater source of embarrassment!

Judas was offended, so he went out to betray his master. The potential for betrayal was already there, but the offense stirred that potential into action. The result of his offense was that he no longer trusted the Lord to do what He said He would. Judas would goad Him into action. If He were the promised Messiah who would establish His kingdom in place of the Roman empire, now was the time to prove it! But only one thing was proved - that he, Judas, was a poor politician and an even poorer friend!

Judas had lost confidence in the Lord! Where is your confidence placed? What do you place your trust and your hope in? Christian ‘hope’ is an eager expectation that what He has promised, He will complete! The hymnist declares “My hope is built on nothing less than Jesus’ blood and righteousness!” (My Hope is Built On Nothing Less, Robert Critchley).

The writer of Hebrews encourages us to “not throw away [our] confidence, which has a great reward” (Hebrews 10:35).

When we are offended, a lack of hope will be the result, and therefore, we will have no confidence !

Peter’s Denial → Matthew 26:31-35, 69-75

Jesus had just come to the Mount of Olives, having instituted the communion covenant with His disciples. He now teaches them that He is about to be taken away from them.

Jesus tells His disciples, that “You shall all be offended because of Me tonight.” But Peter, being brave and foolish, says, “I will never be offended in You, even if everyone else is!” (Matthew 26:31-33). How he must have regretted those words just a few hours later! I feel for Peter because he is so much like me! How wonderful a Savior we have who, feeling his pain, would appear first to Peter after His resurrection, and before the others saw Him (Luke 24: 34). I can only imagine that scene as the two of them were reconciled through the Saviour’s love.

John and Peter entered the house of the High Priest where Jesus was being tried. As Peter passed through the doorway a slave girl said to him, “Aren’t you one of His disciples?” He responded, “I am not!” Then two more times he denies his Lord, adding some choice oaths before the roosters crow.

I like to imagine that young slave girl and her question. Could it have been possible that she was interested in the Lord and wanted to know more about Him? If Peter had acknowledged his discipleship, would she have asked him to tell her about his friend since she wanted to love Him also? However, Peter was offended , and the result of his offense was no testimony !

Many Turn Away → John 6:53-61

In this passage, Jesus is speaking some hard things to His followers. He is calling them to “eat of My flesh and drink of My blood” (John 6:53). Today, in retrospect, we understand this in terms of the communion cup and the new covenant He has called us into, but to them it was a hard saying which was difficult to understand.

Jesus asked them, “Are you offended?”

Are you offended by His call to the discipleship demanded in the communion covenant? The discipleship which is the core challenge of this book? The result of their offense was that many of His disciples went back and walked no more with Him (John 6:66). The result of their offense was no community.

So we have five Biblical examples of those who were offended, with the result that they lost their fruit , confidence , and testimony . Within them there was disunity, and God didn’t do any miracles among them! Therefore we can be sure Satan must have gloated.

The Rock of Offense

Jesus was the cause of much offense! Both Peter and Paul quote the Old Testament in calling Him “a rock of offense” (Romans 9:33 and 1 Peter 2:8).

The Pharisees were offended by Him, demons were offended by Him, and even His family was offended by Him!

But to some He deliberately avoided offending such as the despised tax gatherers. He told Peter to go to the sea where he would find the required tax in the mouth of a fish, “so that we do not give them any offense” (Matthew 17: 24) But to others He seems to deliberately offend!

John the Baptist - Jesus’ Cousin

John the Baptist was second cousin to Jesus and had been born just a few months before Him. He was full of the Holy Spirit even while in his mother’s womb and was the first to show any response to the promised Messiah. He had leapt in Elizabeth’s womb when Mary, the mother of Jesus, had first come to tell the remarkable story of her baby’s conception.

I’m sure the two boys must have spent many hours together during childhood. They had probably played and worked together, run and fought together, and talked and argued together. Perhaps they even talked together about the burden that was growing in each of their hearts.

Finally, John leaves home to answer a strange compulsion. It could have been possible that Jesus was the only one who understood when he announced that he must “prepare the way of the Lord” (Matthew 3:3), and then he left for the desert.

There, John began to preach to all who would listen to him.

“The Messiah is coming soon” he would proclaim, “and we are not ready! Repent and be baptized. Return to your God!”

(Matthew 3:2-12) The people responded, seeking to be reconciled to Jehovah and indicating their new resolve by being baptized in the local stream, the River Jordan. Theirs was a baptism of repentance and a return to orthodoxy.

One day Jesus came to the Jordan River and John cried out to the people, “Behold the lamb of God who takes away the sin of the World!” (John 1:29). John gave witness that he saw a dove descending upon Jesus and remaining upon him.

Moreover, the Holy Spirit had already told John that this would be the sign of the coming Messiah in John 1:34 where it’s written “I have seen and have borne witness that this is the Son of God.”

John was not a popular preacher who ‘tickled men’s ears.’

Most of those who came to hear and see him were looking for a curiosity, hoping that they would be there to hear his condemnation of the self-righteous leaders of the synagogue.

He had some choice things to say to such leaders and the people loved it; however, Herod did not. He was the ruler of the Roman Empire at the time, and was a wicked man who was having an affair with his sister-in-law - an affair that John openly condemned. To silence his voice Herod had John sent to prison.

I can imagine the thoughts of John while in those dungeons.

“Herod, you old fool! You think you are in control and that putting me in prison will silence my voice. But my cousin is the Messiah and He has come to overthrow your little empire and to establish His own kingdom! He’ll get me out of this prison soon, and you will be the one locked away! He has declared that He has come to set the captive free. I can hardly wait to see your face when He does it!” And with that, John sits back in his cell and waits... and waits... and waits... Meanwhile, Jesus continues with His ministry in the nearby villages, not even finding the time to visit John in prison!

Surely, He would at least come to visit him! But because He doesn’t come, John gets offended and subsequently was beheaded! John’s disciples are sent to Jesus to ask a pointed question. “Are you truly the Messiah or should we wait for another?” (Matthew 11:3). “You do not meet our criteria since You are not doing what we expected You to do!”

Jesus replies, “And he answered them, “Go and tell John what you have seen and heard: the blind receive their sight, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, and the deaf hear, the dead are raised up, the poor have good news preached to them. And blessed is the one who is not offended by me” (Luke 7:22-23).

Jesus’ Dear Friend Mary

Jesus had some very special friends who lived in the small town of Bethany. He was just a few miles away when He received news that His friend Lazarus was dying and that his sisters Mary and Martha were grieving for him. “Now Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus. So, when he heard that Lazarus was ill, he stayed two days longer in the place where he was” (John 11:5-6).

We do not read of any miracles, any teaching, or anything that He did during those two days! And Lazarus died! When Jesus finally came to Bethany, Lazarus had been in the tomb for four days and his sisters were in deep sorrow. It is Martha who comes out to greet Him. That is noteworthy, for she was the one we often think of as ‘the drudge’ - the one who was kitchen-bound - while her sister Mary would leave everything to sit at Jesus’ feet, washing them with precious perfume and wiping them with her hair while absorbing everything He said. Today, Mary would be prominent in Christian activity - president of the local Women’s Adoration Group while her sister would be in the background making coffee and serving cookies.

Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if you had been here my brother would not have died” (John 11:21). Jesus assures her that her brother will live again, for He is the resurrection and the life.

I do not hear any condemnation in Martha’s comment, just sadness. She then goes to Mary, to ask her to come to Jesus.

But why isn’t Mary already there? Surely, she knows that He is coming? Everyone would be aware of that, but Mary sat still in the house. Why? May I suggest that she was pouting!

She was offended ! When she comes to Jesus, she falls before Him weeping and says the same words as Martha had. “Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died” (John 11:32).

Note that Jesus does not say the same comforting words to Mary that He expressed to her sister. Could this have been because of the tone of her voice? Accusing? Judgemental?

Instead of comforting Mary, “Jesus wept” (John 11:35), but not because Lazarus was dead - He had known that for some time and also that, in a short while, all would be rejoicing at his resurrection. He didn’t weep because Mary, Martha, and their friends were in sorrow - He had known that they would be for that was natural at the death of a loved one.

He wept because Mary was offended.

Jesus would die for our “offenses,” but He still grieves when we take offense.

On the journey to Bethany, Jesus had told His disciples that people are often offended when they cannot understand. They are walking in the dark (John 11:10). Had He known how Mary would react?

Why Offenses Come

Why does the Lord allow offenses to come? Could it be that His purpose is to reveal to us something about ourselves? Did John have to realize that, though he had declared that, “He must increase, and I must decrease” (John 3:30), that the timetable has to be the Lord’s not his.

It’s easy for us to fall into the trap of trying to manipulate God into doing things our way. It’s too easy to cross the line between accomplishing His will, versus our will. We must not get offended when He doesn’t do things ‘our way’ because only He knows what is best for us, even when we cannot see the reasons for the valleys we experience.

Did Mary need to learn that obedience and trust is far better than prominence and popularity, even in the Lord’s ‘service?’

Greatness in the Kingdom comes to those who would be least, even as servants (Luke 9:48).

What to Do With Offenses

First, you must own it ! The offense is yours! Another has not sinned against you - you ‘took the monkey’ on your own shoulders, so throw it off - or carry it!

Next, examine it ! The Lord allowed it to come that it may teach you something about yourself.

I have had to learn some hard things this way, and I have given you some of the reasons for offenses in the previous chapter. You must study your personality types and learn to major on your strengths. For example, most pastors tend to be melancholics. One gift of the melancholic is the ability to see problems long before others do. This can cause them to be critical of others, offended by their inability to see ‘the obvious,’ and to do something about it. Thank God you are not all like me!

Everybody’s giftings are different. For many years I was offended by others’ failure to recognize my teaching as a ‘gift.’ Everyone thinks they can teach, and I have had to learn to be ‘thick skinned’ when people ignore my giftings and calling as a pastor.

Once you have owned it and examined it , discard it !

By choice, pray about it and bury it! Bless those who have offended you and seek the empowering of the Holy Spirit if the offense seems too heavy - He has promised to be sufficient for all your trials.

“Strive for peace with everyone, and for the holiness without which no one will see the Lord. See to it that no one fails to obtain the grace of God; that no ‘root of bitterness’ springs up and causes trouble, and by it many become defiled” (Hebrews 12:14-15).

Then, the last step to take when the monkeys are on your shoulders, is to forget it ! Do not let the offense dwell in your heart any longer. Hand it off to the Lord, and let it off of your mind and heart.

Finally, do not be the one who causes offense , for, “woe to him through whom they come!” (Luke 17:1)!

The Wounded Soul

The Bible clearly presents to us the devices of Satan as seen in: ● The roaring lion affecting our emotions.

- The arrows of lies affecting our thoughts.
- The ‘monkeys’ of offense affecting our peace.

However, his most effective device is not so clearly understood. He has targeted you from before your birth. He is not omniscient, so he doesn’t know if you will become a believer and an opponent in the battle, so he has tried to wound you before you were aware of any battle. This is evident in the large number of ‘dysfunctional’ people in our churches, but it is my belief that there are many more who struggle, but are unaware of their wound.

A New Creation

When I became a believer I was taught that “if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come” (2 Corinthians 5:17). This verse was used to challenge me concerning the little things of the old nature that still were present in my life. Naturally, I was made to feel guilty. I eased my guilt by reasoning that my old habits weren’t as bad as some of those I saw in others. We were very quick to condemn those who were not so able as we were to overcome their old habits, particularly those obvious “sins” such as smoking and drinking, not to mention

dancing and keeping company with those who do such things! I'm glad I have come to understand this verse better, and to understand something more of the grace of God.

Thank God that in Christ we are fully accepted and reconciled to the Father - that we are justified, forgiven, and made new creatures. However, my teeth did not shed their fillings and return to the undecayed brightness of my youth when I was converted. Indeed, my body has not been made a new creation, rather, it continues to die day by day.

The 'new creation' refers to that part of me which once was dead - my spirit. I am aware that there is much confusion about the difference between the soul and the spirit but, for the purpose of this book, I shall call the spirit that part of me which, now being alive to God, differentiates me from an unconverted person, whose spirit is dead however noble or religious they may be. They, like me, have a body with varying degrees of health, but which will surely die one day, unless the Lord comes before.

We also have souls - our minds, our wills, and our emotions.

Even the non-Christian man has a living soul. At conversion, these are not made a new creation; they carry many wounds from the past and provide a fertile battlefield for Satan. He knows the wounds - after all, his hosts were very active in causing them! For too long we have made many new (and some older) believers feel incompetent in the battle by charging them to be more mature than their wounded souls have allowed them to be. We have urged them to run when their soul is crippled - to fight when their muscles have atrophied! Instead, we should have been ministering to their hurts and wounds, bringing healing through Biblical teaching since the Lord has committed unto us the ministry of reconciliation (2 Corinthians 5:18-19).

Bruises of the Soul

Many people have been subject for most of their lives to continuous criticism and verbal abuse perhaps from a parent or siblings. Their retiring personality invites others to continue this abuse at school or at work, then they enter adulthood with great ‘bruises’ on their soul. They are often accused of being too sensitive, and indeed they are, as a result of the abuse. They function well enough until criticized again when they find themselves unable to handle the pain. New bruises are formed and each new criticism, real or imagined, is like a punch on the bruise.

Peter had been raised in a somber, though Christian home. He was an only child and had few friends. He was not allowed to bring friends home from school because they were ‘worldly’ and there were no other youth his age that attended the small church his family went to. He could never quite meet his father’s expectations or demands and was unable to hold a job for very long. He was never made to feel good enough to be accepted. In his mid-thirties he left home and went to work for a Christian mission where he was befriended by three other men. He began to enjoy his work and friends and became a well-accepted part of that ministry until, just over a year of working there, each of his three friends announced that they would soon be leaving to work elsewhere.

Instead of the usual sorrow one would expect, Peter began to act in a strange way. He deliberately set out to make himself disliked by his departing friends. For example, he would borrow something from one of them, and deliberately break it, claiming that it was an accident. Each of the friends left the mission offended by Peter.

Just why did he act like this? He told me that it had started just after he had returned from holidays - at home. That had not been a good time and he had been glad to return to the mission. When I suggested that his experi-

ence of more criticism at home had produced renewed bruising on his soul, and that the departure of his friends had been like punches on the bruising, Peter broke down and cried. "That's exactly how I feel," he declared, "their leaving just added to my feelings of being unworthy of love and acceptance." Today, Peter is walking in a new freedom, knowing his worthiness in Christ.

Stab Wounds

For others, the wound may have been created by a single act - a wound similar to being stabbed. A classic example, of course, is the child who is sexually abused by a trusted, loved one. In this example, the child does not understand that they are the victim and not the guilty one. They are afraid to speak about the incident, choosing rather, to bury it in their memory.

Sometime afterwards, the wound is covered over and not easily brought to the surface to be faced, even in adulthood.

The 'bandage' with which the wound was covered has become a bondage affecting other areas of the adult's personality. Such a soul needs healing!

When I asked Alec why he couldn't read or write, he told me a sad story. For four years his mother had doted on him, her only child, after his father had walked out on them. Then another father came on the scene - one who did not like or want Alec around him. He soon knew the deep pain of rejection.

At the age of five, Alec started primary school where he would sit in the back of the room, daydreaming. He remembers well the occasion when an unthinking teacher shouted at him. "Alec, you're nothing but a dumb!" The hurting, little soul said to himself, "If that's what you think I am, that's

what I'll be!" He resolved, as a young child, never to study to please that teacher... and therefore grew into a teenage illiterate!

Was Alec bright enough to have learned? Just one month after we talked, Alec was reading all the sports news in the daily newspaper! He had an interest in a young lady and was motivated to walk out healing. I used his knowledge of sports personalities and their photographs in the newspapers, to encourage him in reading the words explaining the pictures.

Soon, he needed no pictures and I watched his self-esteem grow as he began to read with understanding. So many teachers, parents, and others will never know the negative significance of the stabbing wounds their unthinking words have had on so many young souls. Many adults today are still carrying the scabs and scars from those wounds on their souls!

Grazes

Then there's the grazing kinds of wounds. They usually leave no scar or permanent bondage, but can bleed profusely at the time of injury. If not treated correctly, however, they can fester and then produce far worse injury. I see such wounds of the soul occurring when one experiences discouragement or a great disappointment. It is accompanied by feelings of inadequacy and loneliness, and spiritual defenses are down.

This is the time when we need to come around in tender support for the hurting one. It is the time for empathy and understanding.

Mary had become ill with "Epstein Barr" or "Yuppie Flu" which was widely known as the disease of the nineties. It was hard not knowing how long she was likely to be ill, for the doctors had no ready cure. The members of her church were praying for her, but she wished someone would come to visit her. No one came, giving their reason that they were unsure if such a disease was contagious. That was hard to accept, but Mary did so

with grace. Then one day, she received a telephone call which caused much ‘bleeding’ of her soul. Her closest friend called to tell her that the church had stopped praying for Mary since it was obvious she was not exercising faith. Her reasoning being, that if she had been so doing, she would have been well by then.

Fractures

Let us continue with our metaphors. Are there such wounds as fractures in the soul? Yes, and there are many believers who are limping through life because of some traumatic experience. It may be the death of a loved one, a broken engagement, or some accident of life. They were crippled by the experience and have never learned to walk again.

Melinda had an argument with her mother during which she had pushed her away with some force. Some months later, mother was diagnosed as having developed breast cancer, and within a year, had died. No amount of argument could convince Melinda that her push had not created the cancer in her mother. She would not forgive herself and could not accept the Lord’s forgiveness. She was a broken woman when I met her, and to this day, remains crippled.

“He Restores My Soul”

I am convinced that many believers today have wounded souls. I am also convinced that the Lord wants to heal those wounds - to restore the soul. The psalmist David was guilty of adultery and murder; he carried terrible soul wounds, but he could still say, “The Lord is my shepherd... He restores my soul” (Psalm 23:3).

There are also wounds created by our own doings. It seems to me that when we deliberately act contrary to the explicit Word of God, we create our own wounds. Sex outside of marriage and divorce will always create wounded souls that need healing through the grace of God. Be very sure that it is His desire to bring such healing. Indeed, I see this as the true work of sanctification - the second part of salvation.

Justification is when one has been set free from the penalty of sin: salvation for one's spirit. The Holy Spirit has already completed this work.

Sanctification is when one has been set free from the power of sin: salvation for one's soul. This is the present work of the Holy Spirit.

Glorification is when one has been set free from the presence of sin: salvation for the body. This is the work that the Holy Spirit has yet to do.

For these reasons we call Him Savior!

The Angler

We have likened Satan to a roaring lion and an archer; however, it seems to me that his most effective warring device is like an angler's hook and rod -he knows exactly where our soul wounds are. After all, he was instrumental in creating them. When we get ready to enter the battle in the heavenlies, he then casts his line, hooks it into the wound, and manipulates the soul into ineffectiveness.

A Personal Story

Early in 1990 I became closely involved in a new work of God among the native peoples of western Canada. The spiritual battle was intense. I also stopped sleeping at the same time. My doctor tried many different medications to get me to sleep, but it was several weeks before a way was found for

me not to lie awake all night. Many thought I was under an Indian curse and I would receive letters and telephone calls of encouragement from throughout the north-west of America and Canada. I asked Charles and Claudia, another pastor and his wife, to pray for me, at which time she told me that she was aware of a “terrible spirit of abandonment” upon me. I had no understanding of what she meant.

Shortly afterwards, I was invited to spend a week at an Anglican Retreat for clergymen and wives. There I was told that there was an area of my emotions missing and it had much to do with my mother’s death. My mother had died when I was a teenager, and though I had not cried at the time in a normal mourning, I thought I had dealt with her death very well. Now I was being told that this had something to do with my sleeplessness? I still did not understand.

After four months I offered to resign my position at the church, but the elders and members would not let me. Instead, much love was shown to me by them and the greater church body of our city.

After eight months, I entered Vancouver University Hospital as a patient in the sleep clinic where it was diagnosed that there had been a physical breakdown in my body’s production of the sleep-inducing neurochemicals. The specialist put this down to stress. The next week, I was able to resign from the church, which had now decreased to sixty percent the attendance rate it had been at the beginning of the year.

The following Tuesday I was with a group of my closest friends, other pastors who met together weekly for prayer. As we finished our breakfast, one of them said to me, “Gareth, I sense an awful spirit of abandonment upon you!” These were the same words I had heard almost nine months earlier. When I got back home, I called Claudia to ask her to explain to me just what she had meant by her comment. She told me to sit down that

evening and to go back over my life, looking for the times when the little boy in me might have felt abandoned.

My wife Anne and I were amazed as we considered the different periods of my life - there were so many times when I had felt the pain of abandonment, not least of which was my mother's death when I was just fourteen. I had not cried then, but for some time afterwards, I had grieved. Later that same evening I relaxed to read a novel about the Crusades of the thirteenth century.

Two knights were leading their men into battle on the fields of France. Suddenly, they were face to face; however, Sir Rufus had been wounded and was slumped over in his saddle, his sword hanging by his side. His enemy, Sir Nigel, quickly rode toward him, raising his mighty sword to slay his opponent. Just as he would strike the fatal blow, nine arrows from Sir Rufus' bowmen flew through the air to find their target in Sir Nigel's armpit. They were ineffective against his armor, but very effective at his weak spot, where no armor could be worn. I sensed that the Spirit of the Lord was speaking to me.

"Gareth, you might be putting on the armor of God, but when you go into battle against the enemy, be aware that he knows exactly where your weakest spots are - and yours is that of abandonment. They must be healed if you would be effective in the battle!"

I now began to understand why people had been drifting away from our church over the past two years. Three elders had left because of job relocation and had been replaced by three other good men; however, the new elders' board did not have the gifts necessary to maintain the programs initiated by the former men and soon there began a slow exodus from the church. I would meet people on the street who would rush up to me to tell me that they loved me, but had started to go to another church "because our children enjoy their youth work so much." There were many reasons,

but few had displayed the grace to come and tell me of their intentions. I would have gladly given them letters of introduction if I had known they wanted to transfer.

Then, as I grew more weary, I was not feeding and leading my flock as they were used to, so more began to leave. Instead of the fulfillment I was used to, I had the pain, almost every week, of seeing another vacant pew. Since I was very committed to my people, each departure was like a mini divorce. I'm sure that none of those people would have deliberately hurt me, but their actions were used by the enemy as hooks in my wounds of abandonment. No wonder the doctor called it stress, even though I would boast that I never took my church problems home with me!

A personal note for readers potentially planning on leaving your local church: do it the right and ethical way. Let your pastor know of your intentions, because you'd be surprised if you knew exactly how easily we wound one another.

Our Response

God's Priority is Satan's Priority!

We can be certain of this! Whatever God's purposes are for mankind, Satan will do his utmost to hinder that work. If it is the Lord's desire that believers live in unity, the enemy works very hard to hinder such unity.

As we study the Bible it is very evident that relationships are high on God's priority list. He created us for Himself, and for one another. From cover to cover, the Bible emphasizes relationship: man with God, and man with man.

In Genesis, God created man in His own image - that they might have fellowship together (1 John 1:3). Then for the man, He created a woman, because "it is not good for man to be alone" (Genesis 2:18).

Later, He chose one man from whom would come a special nation. He called Himself, "The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob," becoming a Father and husband to their descendants.

Satan did all he could to break these relationships with a lot of help from men themselves! Know that today he is still working frantically to draw men from God, to break up families, and to destroy the Jews.

The Old Testament ends with a wonderful promise concerning relationships, "He will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers, lest I come and strike the land with a decree of utter destruction" (Malachi 4:6).

The emphasis of the New Testament is the same as the old with the added responsibility for the believers of being in unity as a foundation for their witness.

Major sections of the New Testament emphasize this truth, ending with the invitation of the last chapter, “The Spirit and the bride say, ‘Come!’” (Revelation 22:17). “Bride,” like “Body” is a relationship word!

Dysfunctional Wounds

If the Lord would mature a man or woman to become a mighty warrior who is effective in the battle against evil, the enemy will try to ‘cripple’ that soldier even before he enters the army as a cadet.

Satan is not omniscient, and therefore, does not know your future. He is neither omnipresent, to wrestle with you every moment, so he must use ‘guerrilla’ tactics in the warfare, with his soldiers (demons) using a ‘hit or miss’ policy. Clear ‘hits’ are seen in the high proportion of people classified as coming from ‘dysfunctional’ families.

Counselors, both secular and Christian, spend many hours trying to teach people how to deal with their wounds - their dysfunction. They hope to bring their patients to a place of ‘maintenance’ where they learn to effectively use the ‘crutches’ the counselors offer them. For example, the goal of Alcoholics Anonymous is to enable their members to maintain their sobriety rather than bringing them to healing.

Sadly, many Christian counselors have adopted worldly methods and tools in dealing with these wounds, seldom bringing their people to the place of healing that Jesus obtained on the cross. “With His wounds, we are healed” (Isaiah 53:5).

Satan’s devices wound many who will never even enter the army against him, since they will never avail themselves of the salvation offered to them

in Christ. However, when one is recognized as being in the Body of Christ, then Satan concentrates his efforts on that person, especially if they begin to come on the offensive against him.

The Ministry of Reconciliation

Jesus came to defeat Satan's power in the life of men. In Him, our new relationship should be manifested in our unity as believers: as one Body. Satan has no power to destroy this unity or these relationships, but through ignorance, carnality, and the unhealthy wounds of our souls, we have given him strongholds.

What can we do to correct this situation? Of course, we can pray! After all, without the help and guidance of the Holy Spirit, we can do nothing! However, we must realize that the Father will seldom answer prayer in those areas where He has already given the authority and responsibility to us. The responsibility for reconciliation between people, is no longer His, it is ours. "All this is from God, who through Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation; that is, in Christ God was reconciling the world to himself, not counting their trespasses against them, and entrusting to us the message of reconciliation" (2 Corinthians 5:18-19).

We need to deal with our offenses, seek to understand our 'wounds,' and use Biblical principles to obtain healing, restoration, and reconciliation. If you are wounded, I trust that this section of the book will give you some assistance in bringing you to a place of wholeness in Christ, knowing as David did, that "He restores the soul" (Psalm 23:3) and that those, "whom the Son sets free, are free indeed" (John 8:36).

The Offended Sheep

For those who are counselors, elders, or pastors, I would charge you that this is your ministry. A passage of Scripture that greatly challenges me as a pastor and counselor is found in Matthew 18. The entire context of this chapter is dealing with offense, restoration, reconciliation, and forgiveness.

I am particularly challenged by Matthew's account of the parable of the shepherd and the hundred sheep where it is written, "If a man has a hundred sheep, and one of them has gone astray, does he not leave the ninety-nine on the mountains and go in search of the one that went astray? And if he finds it, truly, I say to you, he rejoices over it more than over the ninety-nine that never went astray" (Matthew 18:12-14).

It is a sheep that has left the fold, not a goat. In the New Testament, believers are usually referred to as "sheep" whereas the word "goat" is used for non-believers.

This picture is of the believer who has been offended, and has walked out of the church, possibly with a little poison ready to spread to whomever will listen. All of us have had this happen in our congregations and very often we are tempted to rub our hands together saying, "Good riddance! He was such a miserable man!" Instead, we are urged to go after that sheep, seeking to understand him and to minister to him without condemnation, trusting that the Lord will bring about a reconciliation and restoration. If we did, maybe we would have far fewer 'miserable men' in our church!

Sometimes the sheep leaves feeling deeply wounded. I remember a young lady who came to me, deeply hurt because the leaders of her 'ministry' had disciplined her, having received some bad reports concerning her; however, no one would tell her what the reports said. I went to see her leaders and was told by her chief judge that they were "letting her stew in her

own juice to teach her a lesson.” I told that leader, who considered himself a pastor, that we have no permission to treat the sheep that way.

“If a sheep is caught in a bramble bush, I must crawl in to set it free, even though I may get scratched with thorns and possibly bitten by the hurting sheep. Then I pour in oil and wine and bind up the wounds, before releasing the sheep with the admonition not to go into a bramble bush again. If I hear the bleating again and see the sheep in another bush a little while later, I repeat the process. This continues with more admonition and possible use of a leash, but I can never stand outside the bush, wag my finger and say, ‘Serve you right!’

Stew in your own juice!’ The Great Shepherd gave me no such permission when He called me to serve as an under-shepherd!”

That young lady was dismissed from that ministry, though I had clearly shown her leaders that the reports against her were based on a lie! No wonder she was so badly wounded and needed lengthy professional counseling!

The Key to Release

Much of the counseling I do is to help people deal with their offenses. How many hours would be saved if they knew their personal responsibility and acted according to Biblical principles!

I am of the opinion that one of the major ploys used by the enemy to hinder us in the battle, is the large number of hours spent by pastors (especially in North America), dealing with counseling matters that believers could handle themselves if they were more active in studying the Word.

The role of a pastor should be to do away with most counseling needs of his people, by teaching them Biblical principles. It's his role, as a shepherd, to lead them to 'green pastures' where the sheep feed themselves; however, we have come to the place where the sheep still need to be bottle fed (counseled), every time there is a 'crisis!' Satan has robbed the church of many of its shepherds by overloading them with counseling 'needs.'

A natural analogy is that, if we eat and exercise properly, we will stay in good health; however, one recognizes that there will come times whether through an accident or chronic sickness, that one needs the assistance of another. When there are terrible wounds and the patient is handicapped in some way, the empathy, comfort, and help of another is appreciated. This is the same with spiritual wounds.

There are many Christian books on the market dealing with wounds to the soul. They speak of 'healing the memories' of dysfunctional families and codependency. Many of them are very good and have given a lot of help

to people seeking a new perspective of life and themselves. The ‘12-step’ program by Alcoholics Anonymous has become the basis for much of this teaching, with the goal of bringing the wounded person to a place of ‘maintenance.’ They are then able to deal with their problem in a practical way, with the use of support groups, ongoing counseling, and prescribed plans or a ‘formula’ of action. Each day, they have a prescription to ‘walk out’ their healing. I have used these books and continue to do so in part. What bothers me about most of them is that few of them mention the releasing effect of forgiveness .

I do not believe that the Lord’s intention is to bring His wounded people to ‘maintenance,’ but that He wishes to restore their souls, and bring them healing. The main purpose of this book is to teach how we can be set free from the bondage of our wounds, so that we can be most effective in the warfare against our enemy, Satan. The key of healing is found in forgiveness.

The Keys to the Kingdom → Matthew 16:19

For three years the disciples had walked with the Lord through the regions of Judea, Samaria, and Galilee. They had watched Him perform many miracles and had heard Him teaching the multitudes, but He had seldom sat down just to talk with them. Now, after a very busy time, He leads them to the far north of the country, to the regions around Caesarea Philippi, on the lower slopes of Mount Hermon. As they walk, the master turns to His disciples and asks them two questions.

The first question is concerning men’s opinions of Jesus, whereas the next question is concerning the disciples opinion of Jesus.

After the disciples answer the first question, He again turns to them, and asks, “But who do you say I am?” (Matthew 16:15). Had they come to

understand that Jesus was more than just a good man or a miracle worker?

“Simon Peter replied, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.” And Jesus answered him, “Blessed are you, Simon Bar-Jonah! For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but my Father who is in Heaven. And I tell you, you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it. I will give you the keys of the kingdom of Heaven, and whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in Heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in Heaven” (Matthew 16:16-19).

For centuries, the Roman Catholic Church taught that this is the mandate given to all popes, as successors of Peter, the head of the church, to excommunicate kings, countries, and peoples who do not support their edicts, or grant indulgences.

Wouldn't it be wonderful if you had the key to the kingdom for your loved ones? For your spouse? For your unsaved child? For your parents? If only you could open up the way to eternal life for them! Well, I believe we have that possibility!

It is certain that many are being kept away from the joys of seeing and entering the kingdom by our failure to be the witnesses we ought to be. Much of that failure is in our attitudes of unforgiveness. There are many parents today who pray, with weeping, for their wayward child, not realizing that the unforgiveness they bear against that child is the greatest hindrance to God answering the prayer!

What did Jesus mean by the latter part of the verse above? I have been given many explanations, from the popes ‘authority,’ to ‘deliverance from the demonic,’ but I see neither here.

It is good exegesis when considering an obscure verse, to look for parallel verses, particularly from the same author. In this case, we do not have to go very far, for just two chapters later, Matthew writes it again.

“Truly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in Heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in Heaven” (Matthew 18:18).

This time the Lord is speaking to all the disciples, not just to Peter. If the keys were given to loose and to bind (a common use of keys!), then they were given to all the disciples - including you and me!

A second principle of good exegesis is to study the context, so we will consider what the Lord was teaching in the rest of Matthew 18. We soon see that the entire chapter is dealing with restoration, reconciliation, and forgiveness. The small scenarios speak of being like children, having no guile and holding no bitterness - such believers do not offend or wound, and we should be careful not to cause them offense or wounds.

The second thing I notice is that if one is wounded or hurt, and as a result, goes away, a good shepherd will leave the others to restore that ‘sheep’ to the fold. Note again, that the story is about ‘sheep’ not ‘goats.’ It is about believers, not the ‘lost.’ How often, when a ‘problem person’ leaves the church, we wipe our hands saying, “good riddance!” God’s demand of servant shepherds, and the rest of the sheep, is that we seek their restoration, not their dis-fellowship.

“If a brother sins against you, you are to go to him, privately at first, with the one purpose of seeking understanding and reconciliation” (Matthew 18:15). Note the word “sin .” Too often we leave when we are offended, which in turn, creates an even greater offense. We have no such injunction to go to them when we are offended - only when we are sinned against. The only exception would be, when the church pastor or elders feel it necessary to approach someone who they believe to consistently be a cause of offense, or who has sinned against others. In that case, the purpose of approaching them is always for reconciliation.

When Jesus is giving the teaching of Matthew 18:18-20, a question comes to Peter asking the Lord how many times he should forgive. “Up to seven times?” (Matthew 18:22). Peter probably thought his question was going to be good, but the Lord used it to emphasize that forgiveness is to be unlimited.

Love demands that we always forgive.

The entire context of chapter 18 is to do with restoration, reconciliation, and forgiveness, all without causing offense yourself... the theme of this book!

John 20:23

This verse is another parallel verse to the two above, though it is written by John in John 20:23.

In this verse, the disciples are all in a locked room because they are afraid that the Jewish leaders would soon come to take them, just as they had taken their Lord. Their emotions are running high, and some there claimed that they had seen the Lord, risen from the dead! The story was going around that Jesus had appeared to Peter and Mary Magdalene as well as two others on the Emmaus Road. Others would not believe unless they also saw the risen Lord.

Suddenly, even though the doors were locked, Jesus stood in their midst! He said, “Peace be with you! As the Father has sent Me, I also send you... receive the Holy Spirit” (John 20:21-22).

The Greek tense of “receive,” is the aorist imperative which always demands an immediate response. At that moment, the disciples received their new life in the Spirit. Then later, on the day of Pentecost, they would receive His fullness to empower them for service. They had been given a new authority! “If you forgive the sins of any, they are forgiven them; if you

withhold forgiveness from any, it is withheld” (John 20:23). Allow me to paraphrase, “Those you loose (set free) are loosed; those you bind, are bound.”

“Who can forgive sins but God alone?” (Mark 2:7) asked the Pharisees. In a sense, they were correct because the Lord’s mandate to us does not ‘forgive’ sins to the same measure as His forgiveness. When He forgives it is “as far as the east is from the west to the depths of the sea, never to be remembered anymore” (Psalm 103: 12) . You and I cannot do that - for our own sins, let alone anyone else’s. The only sins we can ‘forgive’ are those committed against ourselves - sins that have likely caused the soul-wounds we bear, by which Satan has hindered us.

Removing the Barrier of Sin

Should I sin against you, I also sin against God. Immediately, a barrier comes between me and my Lord. I find it more difficult to pray, the Word loses its interest, and fellowship is not so sweet -my sin has become a cloud above my head!

There are two ways in which that ‘cloud’ can be removed.

First, is to “confess my sin, [because] He is faithful and just to forgive me my sin and to cleanse me from all unrighteousness!” (1 John 1:9). Hallelujah! I have found that promise to be true.

However, I have also discovered that the Lord has this little ‘habit’ of talking to me about the sin. Having forgiven me, He then whispers to my soul, “Now, go to your brother and for him to forgive you. I don’t just desire to cleanse you from the sin, but I want to see you reconciled.” His priority is not forgiveness - it is reconciliation! The confession is not complete unless it brings about reconciliation. That is not His responsibility - it is

mine, for “Christ reconciled us to himself and gave us the ministry of reconciliation” (2 Corinthians 5: 18-19).

The second way that my ‘cloud’ can be removed, so that Heaven is once more opened to me, is if you remove it by your forgiveness. The King James Version of the Bible uses a special word in its translation of John 20:23, which writes, “Whosoever’s sins you remit...” The word “remit” speaks of ‘setting aside.’ You can remit my sin, which was committed against you, and in doing so, open Heaven up to me. As you ‘set aside’ my sin, you move the ‘cloud’ away, and the way is open for the Father to speak to me just as when I sought His forgiveness for myself. He again will move upon my heart, in order to bring about our reconciliation!

You might choose to forgive me because you know the Scripture demands that, but it is essential if we are to be reconciled, that you also loose me from God’s judgment upon me by seeking to set aside the ‘cloud’ of sin above me.

I always speak of “forgiveness and release” - they must be preached together! A good example would be Stephen, the first martyr. He had just been appointed as a leader in the early church when the Jewish leaders took him and stoned him to death. Saul of Tarsus stood by, in hearty agreement with their actions, for he had a great hatred for these followers of Jesus.

As Stephen died, he cried out in a loud voice, “Lord, do not lay this sin to their charge!” (Acts 7: 60) . He did not pray on behalf of himself for courage, strength, or even to be released, but rather, he released them of their guilt.

I wonder, would Saul have ever become the great apostle Paul, if Stephen had not prayed that prayer? It is my conviction that he ‘opened Heaven’ for Saul! Jesus also prayed a similar prayer where He cried out, “Father, forgive them for they do not know what they do” (Luke 23:34) as He died for you and me.

One wonderful result of releasing others is that we are also released! It's like having a horse on the end of a rope - we might say that the horse is bound as it runs around us in the paddock; however, should the horse decide to gallop off across the muddy field, we are going to get dragged along through the mud unless we let go of the rope!

That knot you feel in your stomach after someone has sinned against you, is just like that rope. You are emotionally bound to those who hurt you. That pain is part of the wound they caused. Though you have forgiven them, the knot is there whenever you meet them or hear someone talk about them.

You, and they, need to be released!

Jesus in the Midst

It is sad how often Matthew 18:18-20 is quoted out of context! These verses are referring to forgiveness, release, and reconciliation, not God's presence when multiple people come together! The promises of Jesus given there, are for those who actively seek to be reconciled.

“Again I say to you, if two of you agree on earth about anything they ask, it will be done for them by my Father in Heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them” (Matthew 18:19-20). The emphasis here is not His presence, for He is always with each of us who are believers, but instead His blessing for reconciliation - His priority!

We have been given a key that will open Heaven for others and that will set us free from the wounds, the bondages they have caused in our soul! Let us learn how to use that key!

Heaven is Opened

I have seen several miracles in my time - including a number of physical healings. I was present when a 12 year old deaf-mute girl received hearing and could talk for the first time. I saw a woman, crippled from birth, walk after prayer. I have seen a large goiter disappear from a woman's neck as she was being prayed for.

However, as much as these miracles thrilled and encouraged me, they were no more spectacular than the miracles of soul-healing I have witnessed in recent years as wounded believers have used the "key to the kingdom of heaven" to release those who have wounded them, and to release themselves.

The following stories are based on true experiences with the exception of altered names and locations to maintain confidentiality; however, I have not exaggerated the outcome in any way, and have tried to be faithful in reporting the miraculous work of the Lord.

Marie

I first met Marie when she was 28. Her counselors were trying to place her under psychiatric care, and she was deeply depressed and withdrawn. She told me of her sad childhood, having been brought up in a strict Jehovah's Witness home in Canada where they never celebrated any birthdays or Christmas. There were no memories of affection from either parent, and

she had never heard her father tell her that he loved her, nor had she ever felt his embrace or received his kisses.

At the age of 16, Marie ran away from home. Several years later, she heard the wonderful news of the Gospel and immediately yielded her life to Christ, desiring to serve Him.

A small local church nurtured her in those early years as she wrestled with her identity and emotions. On one occasion an attempt was made to be reconciled with her family, but the experience was very painful since arguments arose about their differing understandings of Scripture. The parting was acrimonious, and Marie decided that she would never see her parents again. "I hate them," she told me at our first meeting.

Over the next months, I spent many hours with Marie. She looked to me as her father, and I saw in her the little girl who had never grown up. Many of her actions were those of the adolescent, though she was well educated and even bilingual.

She was a hard worker and very competent at her designated task, but her emotions and attitudes were those of an insecure teenager. We talked about many things, but whenever her parents were mentioned, a barrier grew between us.

Finally, I was able to explain that God had created her as a 'heart-shaped' vessel, designed to receive love from her mum and dad. Such love is demonstrated, not so much in the giving of sweets and presents, but in nurturing security, self-worth, identity, comfort, and acceptance by encouraging ambitions and goals, and so much more - things that she never received.

Marie was eager to agree that her parents had sinned against her in failing to pour this love into her, but it was much harder to explain to her that her parents were no different to the great majority of us. They are walking in darkness, bearing their own wounds - their own dysfunction - as victims

of Satan's attacks. They had no desire to hurt Marie and were probably ignorant of the wounds she was carrying.

"I want you to write a letter to your parents," I said. "Don't worry! You won't have to send it, but I do want you to think about what you'd say in such a letter. Tell them specifically, just how they have hurt you, with examples. Also tell them how much you long for their love."

This is a practice I often use in my counseling since it enables the patient to bring the subconscious to the conscious surface.

The letter will not be sent, but it enables them to have something concrete on which to concentrate. It took Marie three tear-filled weeks to complete the letter. As we prayed for the Lord to direct her thinking, she was amazed at the memories He brought back to her.

When the letter was finished, I was invited to read it. This is not essential for the counselor, and I make it quite clear to all I counsel that they do not have to show me what they have written. There was obviously a great deal of pain in this letter, and my heart ached for this lost, little girl hidden inside a woman's body.

I folded the paper and returned it to its envelope. "Marie, will you choose now to forgive your parents and to release them?"

I asked. "I cannot!" she cried through her tears. I told her I could do no more, the remedy for her hurts was now in her hands, the "key to the kingdom" was hers should she choose to use it.

Three more weeks passed before Marie knelt in my office, and with much weeping, told the Lord that she was forgiving her parents and wanted Him "not to lay their sin to their charge." She then promised me that she would pray a blessing upon her parents each day.

A few weeks later, as I saw Marie grow in confidence, I told her that I wanted her to go home to visit her parents for a few days. She protested strongly, but finally agreed to write to see if they would receive her.

It was two weeks later that she rushed into my office, full of excitement. She had received an envelope containing two letters, a brief one from mum saying that she was welcome, and a longer one from dad. The latter was quite clinical and cold, telling her that they had changed homes and that, should she come, it would now be a long journey. She would need to catch an early train in Toronto, change at Montreal, and would then arrive at their home quite late at night. He wasn't sure if he would see her since he had so much work to do; however, what excited Marie the most was that he ended his letter with, "Hugs and kisses, Dad!"

As I saw Marie onto the train at Toronto, I told her I would be praying for her and encouraged her not to get into any religious arguments. "Before you leave" I said, "make sure you ask your dad for those 'hugs and kisses.'" She doubted that she would have the courage, but I assured her of my prayers toward that end.

Late that evening I received a telephone call. "Gareth, it's me, Marie." She sounded so excited and could hardly contain herself as she told me what had happened. As she was changing platforms in Montreal, she suddenly noticed her mother and father standing there! They had journeyed some distance to meet her. Marie was walking toward them when suddenly, her father stepped forward, threw his arms around her and kissed her! O how the angels of Heaven must have rejoiced!

But what had happened? I believe that Marie had opened heaven for her father by her prayer of release. That morning, her Heavenly father had spoken down through that 'opened door' to her earthly father, prompting him to take a day off work and take his wife on a trip to meet their daughter. Then, He had moved upon his heart, causing him to reach out in love to kiss Marie for the very first time. Of course, dad was unaware that his plans and actions were being directed by God.

After two years, Marie had grown into a wholesome, beautiful young lady. She fully reconciled to her family and even moved to their city. She became active in her evangelical church and was even appointed a deaconess. It didn't take long for Marie to find a husband in the church with the plan to serve the Lord as missionaries. God is so good!

Angela

“What’s wrong with me, Gareth?” Angela cried, when she had settled into my office chair. “I wake up each morning so full of fear that I will be making a mistake if I marry John.”

She went on to explain that each morning she was determined to finish the relationship, but, as the day progressed, she knew that she could not, since John was a fine young man whom any girl would be proud to marry. He was a committed Christian and he treated her with courtesy and love. Their interests were similar and both had a desire to serve the Lord in missionary work.

Angela knew that the problem was hers since this was not the first relationship in which she had felt such fear. Twice, she had ended good relationships and then cried for weeks afterwards wondering why she had been ‘so foolish.’

In our counseling, she told me of a father who was an elder in a healthy evangelical church. She respected him greatly, but felt she could never satisfy him. He had made it known that, for his first child, he had wanted a boy instead of a girl. As she grew up, Angela would play cricket with her father and her younger brothers. She was good, but never quite as good as her brothers were so she never received the plaudits that they did. When she received an A grade at school, she was asked why it wasn't an A+. When she took her first job in a bank, she was told that she should have applied to an-

other, better, bank. She had never heard her father's commendation or affirmation though she had tried so hard to please him.

I suggested to her that her dad had failed to give her identity and worth, that her self-confidence was low because she constantly saw herself as unable to satisfy the men in her life.

Satan was using the wounds produced by her father's lack of acceptance of her, to hinder her in developing a Godly relationship with John. Angela saw the pattern and understood how she could break the bondage by healing the wounds through release of her father. We prayed together as she asked the Lord "not to lay this sin to my father's charge."

Some weeks later, Angela developed some kidney stones.

She left the area where we were working together to return to her home state, where she would enter a hospital for surgery.

Two months later, when I met her for the first time since the operation, she ran up to me, threw her arms around me, and with great excitement, told me an amazing story.

When she had arrived home, her father announced that he was taking five weeks off work so that he could spend it with his daughter! He took her out to meals and to visit local places of interest. They talked together and discovered so many things about one another that neither had known before. There were many visits to the places where her father worked, and at each, she was embarrassed because he would boast about his daughter and the wonderful things she was doing. He was so proud of her!

"Gareth," she said, "I've fallen in love with my father!" Then she added, "and I could hardly wait to get back to see John."

John and Angela happily got married and together, served the Lord with joy.

What had prompted her dad to take five weeks off work to spend with his daughter? Could it have been the Lord speaking to him through the

door opened by Angela's prayer of release? I certainly believe so.

Tony

It took quite an effort for Tony to pluck up courage to visit me. He did not relate very well to any man, having been brought up by his mother after an angry divorce.

Since leaving school, there had been a succession of jobs, but he had failed to keep any of them. I listened as he gave me his excuses and soon saw a pattern that it was always "my supervisor's fault."

We talked together about his childhood, loneliness, and dislike of school. It soon emerged that he had a great fear of one of his teachers. He had not been a brilliant student and this particular teacher had been quite cruel in some of the things he had done and said. His teacher seemed to delight in making his students uncomfortable in class and would embarrass the more sensitive ones by mocking them in front of the class. Tony was often the target of his barbs.

Then there were the threats. Hardly a week went by without Tony being threatened with a trip to see the headmaster because his work was not "up to standard." Even though he worked harder, he could never satisfy this teacher, and was often given extra work to do. He was so glad when he was old enough to leave school and to start earning money; however, it soon became evident that wounds remained since Tony was unable to relate to any dominant man in a position of authority. Whenever he was given an unpleasant task to do, he took it as punishment meted out by a supervisor who must have disliked him. He could not see that it was a task normally expected of any young employee of that company.

I explained how we often get wounded by the actions or words of others and how those wounds hinder us in walking out a life in the freedom

Jesus bought for us on the cross.

Tony understood how his teacher had been used by Satan to wound his soul. Together we prayed as he chose to forgive and to ask the Lord to forgive that teacher. He committed himself to prayer for his family, and in particular, for his sons who were quite rebellious which had been causing much heartache to their parents.

Soon another work opportunity was opened, and Tony applied. He was given the job and started within a few days.

A year later he was promoted to foreman because he had developed such a good relationship with his colleagues. Also, as the company owner declared, “You can give him any task to do and you know it will be done well. He’s a man I can trust!” God had done a good work.

Jesus - The Healer

Generational Sins

Through my years of counseling, I have learned that wounds hindering my patients in their walk with the Lord, often go back to causes many years earlier. Sometimes, there is evidence of a line of similar wounds through several previous generations. It is a Biblical truth that, “the sins of the father may come upon the children to the third and fourth generation” (Exodus 20:5) .

Further, there was a barrier to the children of illegitimacy coming into full fellowship with the congregation of the Lord “even to the tenth generation” (Deuteronomy 23:2)! These are Old Testament judgements showing how sin can affect, not just the sinner, but many of his descendants. Thankfully, Jesus came to remove the curse of sin and to set us free from its effects, therefore, we do not have to continue in bondage to the wounds of our parents’ sin.

The Lord wants us to walk free, but how can we release those who caused the wounds if they have already died? If we cannot release them, can we be released ourselves? These are the types of questions I am often asked as the counselees recognize the wounds of the past and the patterns of the present. We do not believe that praying for the dead will change in any way, their standing before God, the Great Judge, therefore, we unfortunately cannot open the kingdom of heaven for them.

Even though we cannot use the key to the kingdom that has been given to us, the Lord still will set us free by the healing He purchased on Calvary, because it was “by His wounds we are healed” (Isaiah 53:5).

Hidden Memories

Whenever I counsel someone, we always start by asking the Holy Spirit to direct our thoughts. We want Him to reveal to us the areas of the soul where wounds may be found.

It constantly amazes me (though it shouldn't) how often memories of long-forgotten events come flooding back! On one occasion, I was counseling a middle-aged lady who was having some relational problems. She started to quietly sob for no apparent reason.

My assistant, Debbie, moved over and put her arms around her, at which the counselee began to weep uncontrollably.

Debbie took her onto her lap and hugged her as a mother would a small child. After a few moments of deeply emotional tears, the patient began to beat upon Debbie with her fists, crying out “Why did you do it? Why did you do it?”

As she calmed down, she told us that she had thought she was beating her mother for throwing out her favorite rag doll when she was just four years old! The little girl had carried that wound for over 40 years even though she had not remembered it! It had been buried in the subconscious.

Many times patients have returned to tell me of a sudden recall of memory of some traumatic event of the past. I do not automatically assume that these recalls are all accurate. There is a great danger today because many people want to blame others for imagined sins of the past, and they want to excuse themselves from blame for present weaknesses and attitudes.

That is not my purpose in writing this book. I want to see people take responsibility for their own actions, to exercise the key to the kingdom of Heaven, to set themselves free, and to release those who may have wounded them. Both are victims of Satan - both need to be set free. Recrimination never produces freedom, only forgiveness does!

The Same Yesterday, Today and Forever

As the Holy Spirit reveals wounds, we must take time to present that wound before the Lord, for His touch of healing.

He is the “alpha and omega, the beginning and the end” (Revelation 1:8). He is “the same yesterday, today and forever” (Hebrews 13:8) . He knows your wound - He was there when it happened - and He wept for you. As we present the wound to Him, with forgiveness for the one who caused it, He begins to heal and to restore the soul. Even though we cannot release the one who wounded us, the Lord is faithful to heal and to release us.

The Letter

When the patient and I have talked, and they have recognized the hurts, wounds, and patterns, I invite them to write a letter to the person who wounded them outlining the perceived wound and the pain it caused. I encourage them to express their feelings and longings.

“If only you understood how much you hurt me when you... Oh how much I longed to hear you tell me you loved me!”

The letter can be very detailed because it will not be sent. Its purpose is to bring to the surface all the subconscious feelings and pain. When the time for forgiveness and release (if possible) comes, this letter becomes the

‘contract’ of forgiveness. “Are you willing to forgive for all that you have written down here?” I ask them. Then when I am confident that they have fully understood what I have taught, and that they have truly forgiven (and released) the offender, I invite them to destroy the letter making note of the location and date of their action. They are then encouraged to pray blessings upon their offender, if they are still alive.

In order to complete their release, I have known of people who took the letter to a local cemetery, where they have sprinkled its ashes and placed flowers upon the grave of the departed. For some, this has been the first time they have truly mourned over the death of a family member, even a parent, and have known the healing touch that follows true mourning.

Our conscious act of forgiveness breaks the power of Satan.

As the Lord does His work of healing in our lives, we learn to walk in the power of His Spirit.

As we take upon ourselves the whole armor of God, the enemy finds that we have no area of weakness in our lives by which he can hinder us in the battle.

Of course, forgiveness is not a one-time event or even a seven-time commitment. As Jesus taught Peter, it is a “seventy-times-seven” (Matthew 18:22) requirement. In other words, we are to have a continuous forgiving attitude.

We must always be quick to be reconciled with those whose actions or words may cause a division between us. One must recognize that there could very well be a need to ‘cool-off,’ but there can be no excuse for ongoing animosity.

May we become so committed to exercising the key in our hands that we will be known as ‘peacemakers,’ those who are known as the children of God (Matthew 5:9).

Walking Out Your Healing

In many ways, this is the most difficult chapter to write. I have taught the principles outlined in the earlier chapters, to many different groups of people. There have been youth groups and seniors, to liturgical congregations and non-conformist, to Bible colleges and home groups. In almost all of them, there has been an emotional response, with many weeping people coming to me seeking counsel.

I am saddened that I am usually just passing through, and am unable to commit myself to the long process of walking out the healing so many of them require. I am aware that I have often ‘opened a wound’ - a memory long suppressed - that now needs healing.

Sometimes their response is quite unexpected. I remember one Episcopalian congregation made up of mature adults, who broke into applause as the pastor and I embraced as we acted out the reconciliation that follows release. They were very conscious of their need to forgive and release a former pastor of that church, and excitement at their new understanding of how they could be relieved of the pain they bore, caused them to break out into spontaneous applause. We immediately lifted that applause as a praise offering to the Lord.

I hope that this book will awaken many pastors and counselors to the tremendous responsibility we have to bring reconciliation and healing to the broken relationships and wounded souls that are so prevalent in our churches. I further hope that many believers will learn how to operate the

keys that open the kingdom of Heaven for their loved ones, and bring release to themselves from the wounds that they have carried for too long.

It's about time Satan was put in his place and the people of God were able to walk in wholeness and power, rather than limping along as so many do!

For those who may have recognized themselves as wounded as they have read this book, I am closing with some guidelines that will enable them to 'walk out' their own healing. If it is possible to find a good counselor who will walk through this with you, such a companion would be of utmost value. I would encourage you to urge them to become familiar with this book before you start.

Ask the Lord to Direct Your Thoughts

Be assured that the Lord wants to heal your soul wounds. He is aware of them, but has given you the key to being healed, and wants you to use it! He will not answer prayer in the areas of our lives where He has already won the victory on the cross, and where He has given the authority or mandate to us.

Take Your Time

Healing rarely comes quickly. Most of the stories I can tell relate to many months of counseling. It takes time to walk again after a bad wound.

Just as physiotherapy is essential if we are to walk again after a bad accident-causing leg injuries, so spiritual therapy is essential to walk out our healing after long-standing soul-wounds.

Talk About Your Past

I usually encourage the counselee to break their past down into short time periods. For example, preschool, junior school, teenage years, young adult, etc. I prompt them with questions about their home, school, friends, things they love, and things they hate, meanwhile assessing for patterns of attitudes or hurts. “How did the little child inside you feel?”

Ask the Lord to touch each wound as it is revealed.

Write Down Anything You Feel Is Relevant

I always have a pen and paper handy to note any patterns that may be emerging or any thoughts that strike me. During the days when no counselor or friend is with you, you will become surprised as memories come of things long forgotten, but why should you be surprised when you have already asked the Lord to be actively involved in your healing process? Make a note of these memories.

Recognize if You Have Been Wounded by Another's Sin

Do not blame another if the sin is your own. If you have taken offense, you must deal with it as described in chapter nine.

Do not go into denial if the one who has wronged you is someone you love, and certainly do not make excuses for them. God sees them as a sinner, just like you and me - and sinner's sin! There's no need to beat around the bush - just call it as it is - sin! He may be a redeemed sinner, but he is still capable of wounding you.

Most often, the wounds were created unintentionally, but they are real wounds, and if the offender were not a sinner, they would not have been so injurious to you.

As I came to understand this principle, I saw how I had probably wounded my own daughter through ignorance.

Anne was in hospital for a few weeks before the birth of our first daughter, Corinne, so when she began labor, I was at home, unaware of what was happening. Two friends were the first to tell me of her labor since they had called the hospital just before departing on vacation. The nursing staff told them that the baby was born, but would not be specific about the birth details, especially the sex of the child - the father would be the first to be so informed. They urged me to phone the hospital so that they could know the details before beginning their vacation. I told them that I would do so after finishing the Agatha Christie novel I was reading! Of course, I was joking, just to keep them in suspense, and we quickly went together to the public call-box to hear the exciting news that I was now the father of a lovely baby girl.

However, that story was repeated many times to visiting friends over the years, and sometimes, in the presence of my daughter. I never thought about how she was hearing the story - that daddy didn't really care when she was born. Perhaps he did not want her?

Just two years after first publishing this book, I wrote to Corinne asking her forgiveness for the wounds caused by my thoughtlessness.

Write a Letter, Being Specific About Your Hurts

You do not have to show this letter to anyone, though you may choose to confide in your counselor. However, this should only be if they can be trusted with confidentiality, and you know that he will not allow your information to affect his attitude toward you or the one who wounded you. Try to be comprehensive and objective in the letter, writing down how you felt when wounded: rejected, belittled, embarrassed, etc.

Try to also add any positive things you can say.

Being objective may be very difficult as this letter can raise strong emotions and pain. Its purpose is to enable you to bring emotions you have suppressed for years to the surface.

Bandages that have become bondages have to come off! Take your time!

Choose to Forgive

Recognize that the one who wounded you is a sinner walking in darkness. They are blind to what they have done to your soul. Your real adversary is Satan whose army has targeted you from birth, and your offender is but an agent, ignorant of Satan's devices. Get angry at Satan, and forgive the blind man. Make sure you are prepared to forgive for every item mentioned in the letter you wrote.

Do not expect the Lord to heal where you are not prepared to forgive.

Choose to Release

Why not use the prayer of St. Stephen? "Father, do not lay these sins to their charge! Today, I choose to release them from all guilt."

After praying that prayer, I suggest you make a note of the date, recording it in your memory just as you would a birthday.

Burn the Letter!

The matter has been dealt with - why keep it hanging around?

This should be recorded in your memory only as the day on which you started to walk out your healing - a day for celebrating!

Pray for the One Who Wounded You

Commit yourself to pray each day for God to bless the one who wounded you. Are his children far from the Lord? Pray for them. Is his business in difficulty? Pray for its success. As you continue to pray in this way, God will work through the channel between Himself and them - a channel that you opened by your forgiveness and release. In doing this, you will be delivering yourself from slavery to the emotional bondage of your wounds and becoming the servant Jesus called you to be.

If one wrongs you by taking your shirt, he makes you his slave, but by giving him your coat also, you make yourself his servant. If he wrongs you by forcing you to go a mile, he makes you his slave, but by going two miles, you make yourself his servant (Matthew 5:40-41). If he wounds your soul, you become an emotional slave, but by praying for him, you become his servant.

The first call of discipleship is to become a servant , just as Jesus was for you.

Be Open to Reconciliation

Should there be an opportunity to be reconciled to the one who wounded you, do not let apprehension or fear hinder you.

The Lord's priority is not just the healing, which blesses you, but the reconciliation which blesses Him!

Walk Out Your Healing

Each day, take upon yourself all the armor of God as found in Ephesians 6:10-18. Make this a conscious action, even speaking out as you do it. "I take on the belt of truth so that my 'inner man' may not be wounded by the

lies of the enemy. I take on the breastplate of righteousness so that the enemy may never cause my heart to be divided in its commitment and love for the Lord” and so forth. Only the “pure in heart” shall see God - those whose hearts are unalloyed with the dross of this world (Matthew 5:8).

Give Each Wound to the Great Physician

Just as surely as the enemy knows where your wounds are, so does the Lord. He felt your pain when you were hurt and longs for your healing; however, He has given the key to you.

As you begin to use it, He is very willing to assist in the walking out of the healing. As He has revealed the wounds to you, so He removes the bondages and brings wholeness in their place, after all, He is the “Great Physician,” the healer, who took up our infirmities and carried our sorrows and, by whose wounds we are healed (Isaiah 53:4-5).

Lastly, thank Him for His healing!

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